

INFOHAZARDS

a television play in four parts.

New York City
2026

TITLE CARD: I

INT. PRINCIPAL'S OFFICE - EVENING

PRINCIPAL (cheap-suited, full of pragmatism and awkward gravitas) walks from his desk to the window. Outside a violent thunderstorm rages. Lightning strikes, illuminating a dirty, disordered office.

PRINCIPAL
Good lord. What a storm.

A child, MORGAN (9, shaken, frail, in school uniform) sits with his hands crossed in his lap. He looks like he's been crying. He jumps as thunder sounds. He touches the cross on his beaded necklace.

MORGAN
Must be evil tonight, sir.

Principal returns to his long wooden desk, on which an old laptop and a pair of over-ear headphones lie crossed.

PRINCIPAL
Never mind that. Your *numbers*,
Morgan, have fallen very low, and
not just in the workshop--

A knock at the door.

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)
Oh, Yes! Do!

A child, PHINUIT (9, unnervingly calm, melancholy, in school uniform), and his father, GRAY CHOATE (a fallen old-money type, distant, self-absorbed), enter. Principal closes the computer and stows the headphones.

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)
Ah, Mr. Choate, Phinuit, welcome
in.

Morgan stands, smiling weakly towards Phinuit with lowered gaze.

MORGAN
Hello Phinuit.

PHINUIT
Hello Morgan.

Phinuit takes Morgan's hand lightly, without a shake, then drops it and drifts to the window.

Rain beats against the glass. Gray shakes Principal's hand and sits down opposite him in the free seat next to Morgan's.

GRAY

So, Principal, what is it you need to speak to my son and I about?

MORGAN

(meekly correcting "and I")

And me, Sir.

GRAY

Fine, and you, Morgan. But, *with haste*, eh, company? I can't stay long. It's not convenient for me to be here--ever, actually. I'd rather not let this eat up my free evening.

Phinuit has his face pressed against the window-glass, his eyes closed. His life is pain.

PHINUIT

You have every evening free.

GRAY

Thus the inconvenience.

Principal eyes the CLOCK. 8:00 pm.

PRINCIPAL

It's about Phinuit's behavior yesterday. Perhaps you've heard?

Gray takes a notebook and pen from his inside jacket pocket. Laying these on his lap, he then removes and dons a pair of reading glasses from his breast pocket. He flips a sheet or two back. The notebook is full of illegible scrawl.

GRAY

Hmmm. Yesterday? No, I haven't got anything for that.

Gray removes his glasses, closes his notebook, and looks up at Principal, blinking.

PRINCIPAL

Well, it came to us that your Phinuit was going around to his classmates -- and they're quite *impressionable* -- going around and *telling* them things. Tales, tall tales.

Phinuit snickers and sets about examining his fingers.

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)

And he's scared some of them. Very badly, Mr. Choate.

Gray nods and performs the whole operation again to take a note in his notebook, as he will do every now and then through the conversation hereforward.

GRAY

"Tall tales"?

PRINCIPAL

Ghouls, you know: monsters, *demons*, witches. Wickedness!

Distant thunder. Morgan shivers and lets out a groan. He touches his necklace. Phinuit shakes his head in disapproval of everything.

GRAY

Phinuit? Have you really been selling this nonsense?

PHINUIT

(extreme condescension)

I deal in sense alone. And I do not sell it; I give it freely. Ask Morgan.

PRINCIPAL

Morgan?

Morgan nods gravely, eyes wide.

MORGAN

He told no tales.

GRAY

Then what scared you so?

MORGAN

Something worse than any tale.

GRAY

(incredulous)

Worse than tales?

Phinuit looks out the window as lightning flashes outside. He smirks, fingering his own cross, which he has mounted upside down. Principal sighs.

PRINCIPAL

As I understand it, your Phinuit has been telling his classmates that -- and I quote -- "the scariest thing you can imagine is real."

Thunderclap. Gray raises an eyebrow.

GRAY

Now how's that, Phinuit? "The scariest thing you can imagine is real"?!

Phinuit whirls around to face them.

PHINUIT

I can prove it, if you'll let me.

GRAY

Young man I should hope you can.

MORGAN

You will wish you hadn't.

PHINUIT

Principal, a cigarette please. For the demonstration.

Principal hesitates, but produces one from a box on the desk. Phinuit begins smoking, opening the window now and then to blow smoke out. Wind whips the curtains and water sprays in, forming a puddle on the floor. When not smoking, he paces the room. There is something of the magician in his demeanor.

PHINUIT (CONT'D)

Imagine, if you will, the scariest thing you can.

Morgan covers his face with his hands.

MORGAN

Mine has to do with a car...

PRINCIPAL

Death for me--give me death, alone, tomorrow.

GRAY

I select free-fall.

PHINUIT

Fine. What's important is to form a clear and distinct idea of your scariest thing.

Everyone does.

PHINUIT (CONT'D)

Now the heart of it: whether this thing is real or not is already included in the idea of it.

(weighing his words)

Let's do it this way. Suppose, for the sake of contradiction, that the scariest thing you can imagine is not real. If that were true, it would be easy to think of something scarier: the same thing, only real! Clear contradiction, since we started with that *than which nothing scarier can be imagined*. For any well-formed scariest thing, its reality follows directly from its scariest-ness. Q.E.D.

Phinuit finishes his cigarette and flicks it at the trashcan.

PHINUIT (CONT'D)

Kobe! God I'm tired.

Phinuit suddenly lies down on his back on the floor. Principal taps his forehead in thought. Gray too is using all his intellect to come up with an objection. He squints at the notes he's made in his notebook.

PRINCIPAL

Logic problem, eh? Let's see what I can do. It's not for nothing they used to call me the Principal of Sufficient Reason! Ha! Hmmm...

(idea)

Suppose I'm scared of unreal objects?

GRAY

Oh, yes, why didn't I think of that? Unreal objects. What then, Phin?

PHINUIT

(not stirring from ground)

Two easy counters present themselves.

(MORE)

PHINUIT (CONT'D)

But let me first note, though I'm not insulted: your argument is in extremely bad faith. There is nothing *scary* about nonexistent things. For there is no possibility of entering into any decomposing relation therewith--and that, it's plain, is the condition that structures fear. Now, counter one--

PRINCIPAL

Hold now! What about loss? Death, like mine? Disappearance?

MORGAN

(whispering)

Or what about a car with no--

GRAY

(rudely shushing Morgan
with wave of hand)

A lack, Phin, what about a lack?

PHINUIT

Kindly allow me to *finish* and you may know. Even as you are known.

Lightning strike. Phinuit looks sour. His explanations are delivered with increasing condescension and less magician's flourish.

PHINUIT (CONT'D)

Counter one: the same argument applies as in the positive case. Why? Because the nonexistence of some object--be it yourself, a lover, or the world entire--is not the absence of the existence of something, as we naively imagine, taking language at its word, but rather something larger than and including the apparently absent object. It is the object *plus* the idea of its negation *and* the context in which that negation occurs. Hence nonexistence relies on and implies (by priority) the existence of that scariest thing. The argument holds. Q.E.D.

Gray scribbles more notes in his very strange handwriting. Morgan peers over at it with curiosity.

PHINUIT (CONT'D)
Now the second--

GRAY
(dismissive wave of hand)
I think one counter is enough,
Phinuit. This all seems tediously
airtight. I'm ready to go meet the
free evening.

Gray checks his watch and closes his notebook.

MORGAN
(tugging at Gray's sleeve)
The car *I* can imagine has no way to
get in, no doors or windows.

GRAY
Eh? What's scary about that?

Morgan shrugs with a look of terrified incomprehension.

PRINCIPAL
But it has tires and a steering
wheel and so on?

MORGAN
Tires, yes. Steering wheel, who
knows? *There's no way in.*

GRAY
What color is it?

MORGAN
The steering wheel? Hard to be
sure, *there's no way in.*

Morgan motions to borrow Gray's notepad.

MORGAN (CONT'D)
(to Gray)
Give me.

Gray releases it to him, taking a real look at Phinuit, who
props himself up on an elbow on the floor.

PHINUIT
Principal, may I borrow your
computer? For the demonstration?

PRINCIPAL
Isn't the demonstration over?

PHINUIT

I ... need your computer for the next part.

PRINCIPAL

(glancing at laptop)

No. It's low battery.

Gray walks to Phinuit, awkwardly pats him on the forehead and steps to the door.

GRAY

Well, if it's alright with anyone, I think I'll go. I'm no help with problems and I've no head for tales. The words just *spin*.

(sigh)

Ah, English. Well, the evening beckons! Tonight I shall wander the town red!

Another step to the door.

PHINUIT

Green. The town green.

GRAY

Oh, yes. Whatever.

PRINCIPAL

Paraphasia. You ought to lay off the poetry a while.

GRAY

No, a separate quirk entirely. I have color oppositeness. What you see as red, I see as green. For example a strawberry. That's green to me. Goodnight!

Gray hurries for the door.

PHINUIT

(standing)

Wait, Father, may I borrow your phone?

GRAY

(disarmed, confused)

Hm? Oh, no. I sold my passcode.

PHINUIT

You *sold* it?

GRAY

Yes. This orphanage isn't free, you know. And caring for you was never really my *thing*. So when your mother passed ... on marrying me ... it was the only solution, installing you here. I don't like it any more than you do. In a just world, you'd be paying your own way.

PHINUIT

I like to think I do my part.

GRAY

(cruel laugh)

Oh really? You can't eat *words*, Phinuit, no matter how ... well-connected. And when was the last time you actually *sold* one of those paper airplanes?

Morgan is sketching a car underneath some crabbed lines of verse in Gray's mysterious alien script. He starts sketching in a door, then angrily crosses it out.

PHINUIT

Morgan bought one. So long as we're talking *nonsense*, Father: when was the last time you sold a poem?

GRAY

You are an impossible child.

Morgan, frustrated, breaks the pen in half and ink gets all over him and the notebook. He quickly shuts the notebook, drops it, and kicks it under the desk. He searches his pockets, getting ink all over his shirt and pants.

PHINUIT

Evidently not. And I don't believe you about the passcode, by the way. Who bought it?

GRAY

(defensive)

An old woman!

PHINUIT

What does she want with a passcode?

Morgan takes a crumpled paper airplane from his pocket. He flattens it and begins with his fingers to draw the car afresh.

GRAY

I don't know! She wouldn't tell me.

PRINCIPAL

Number scavenger.

Principal leans back in chair, gets up and goes to look at a photograph on the wall opposite the window. It shows a broken bridge.

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)

A lot of drifters these days do it. Serial numbers, barcodes. There's a big market for random numbers now. I've no damn idea. Economics--all greek to me. I'm actually busy running this place. But there's something romantic about that scavenger lifestyle. Spend all day in the alleys of the hospital district, stripping digits off any discarded whatever...

GRAY

Say, Phinuit, does that interest you? Perhaps I could set you up with one of these drifters as an apprentice?

Phinuit walks over to Principal's desk and sits in his chair.

PHINUIT

Anything would be better than this place.

Morgan and Principal nod in depressed agreement. Lightning strikes slowly.

GRAY

(rubbing hands)

Suppose I found one who really could use the help--some vagabond with dyscalculia. A rough figure--sometimes one counter's not enough. You'd really consider that, Phin? You promise?

Phinuit nods. He opens Principal's computer and plugs it in. A slow thunderclap.

PRINCIPAL

That reminds me, Morgan, we were interrupted.

(MORE)

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)
 Your mathematics grades are in the
 rather proverbial toilet, you ...
 you know that?

Morgan finishes his finger drawing of the car and gives it to
 Gray, who barely glances at it.

MORGAN
 Yes sir.

PRINCIPAL
 Ah. There goes my hypothesis. So
 what's up, little friend?

MORGAN
 Well, Sir, perhaps if I were
 allowed to spend a bit less time
 stringing beads--

PRINCIPAL
 (clicking tongue)
 Impossible. Those necklaces are
 just about the only thing in the
 gift stall that still sell.

MORGAN
 Yes but now the abacus makes my
 eyes cross--

PRINCIPAL
 Stop. We cannot reduce your hours
 in the workshop. We could reduce
 your pay?

MORGAN
 Pay?

PRINCIPAL
 Ah, perhaps not. Business matters
 are really the Abbess's concern.
 How...
 (idea)
 Tell me, Morgan, do you have a
 little sweetheart? Someone you care--
 -

Suddenly a blaring alarm disturbs everyone. It comes from
 Principal's computer. Flashing lights light up Phinuit's
 face. He shrieks with fright and fascination.

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)
 ARGH! What did you do!?

PHINUIT

I think you have a virus.

PRINCIPAL

(snapping angrily)

Of course I have a virus! But I've learned to live with it. If I keep it low battery, it won't flare up.

Principal rips out the power cord and leans over the computer, furiously hunt-and-pecking.

MORGAN

How did you get a virus, sir?

PRINCIPAL

Pirating music software. One night I was up looking for new wavetables and there was a section on the site I'd never noticed before. *Viruses*. I couldn't resist.

GRAY

What kind of music do you make?

PRINCIPAL

Folk songwriter, orphanage--

PHINUIT

(fascinated)

What are all these images?

Morgan and Gray come around to the other side of the computer to look. Despite himself, Gray is drawn in. Both lean close.

A stream of what seem to be a personal photo album with date-stamps. Most include a woman, MARION (~30, magnetic, self-assured). In between the photos the screen flashes red and a laughing skull gif overlay fades in and out.

PRINCIPAL

I don't know. It's just a thing. The woman, her name is Marion. Some of the pictures you can see it. Like on a cake or a novelty check. If you watch long enough you'll see she ...

(soft, pining sigh)

She really is a remarkable woman.

PHINUIT

Have you...ever tried to find her?

MORGAN

Maybe that's what the virus is for.

PRINCIPAL

Oh no, no. It's random.

MORGAN

(astonishment)

Look, sir, she's just aged!

Marion looks older in this photo, maybe fifty-five. Her hair is almost completely gray. She poses with a rhinoceros she's shot.

PRINCIPAL

The photos aren't in age order.
I've seen her as a teenager and an
old widow. There's a few baby
pictures. The woman lead a lot of
lives. She was at Abu Ghraib.

A photo of Marion younger at a drag show in Miami. Principal chuckles.

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)

Yeah, Miami. Fun, but I think she
was glad to leave. Went up north,
into the city. Her sister got her a
job nursing.

A photo of Marion in a hospital bed, close to death, but only thirty or so years old. Morgan gasps. Phinuit touches his cross necklace.

GRAY

But how...

PRINCIPAL

This is when her twin died. Tragic,
but... it freed her in a way. Poor
Saline.

MORGAN

That's *today's* date!

PRINCIPAL

Hmm, so it is...I wonder--
(eyeroll)
Oh boy.

A photo of BILL, kind of hippie looking, handsome, dirty, playing a weird instrument. Principal pulls an apple from his desk drawer and starts roughly eating it.

GRAY
Who's this?

PRINCIPAL
That's *Bill*. "Dr. James."

GRAY
Lover?

PRINCIPAL
Big time.

A photo of Bill in bed in the middle of a few other people.
All sweaty and laughing.

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)
I never liked Bill.

GRAY
You're jealous.

PRINCIPAL
Of course I am. You would be too,
if you knew Marion like I do. But
Bill's easy to dislike. He killed
her twin.

GRAY
Do you love her?

MORGAN
(alert distress)
What? Her boyfriend killed her
twin?

PHINUIT
There's a picture of that?

A photo of Marion posing with an gator she's shot with a
giant trumpet gun. A speech bubble coming from her head says
"Not bad for my First Gator!"

MORGAN
Miami again, sir.

PRINCIPAL
Very good, Morgan. Uh, no. You
don't see him do it, obviously. But
you get so much information you
basically know. He was *in* Saline's
hospital room that night.

GRAY
But how can you be sure?

PRINCIPAL
It's not interesting to explain.

A photo on the great wall of China dated 2040, Marion wearing a Cleveland Indians shirt and Washington Redskins hat.

MORGAN
Aw c'mon Marion...

PRINCIPAL
(sucking teeth)
Different times. But yeah,
sometimes, I think she was a little
too liberated by Saline's death.

Phinuit has a flash of intuition. He touches his cross.

PHINUIT
(dreamlike, to self)
He thought it was her.

GRAY
Different times? The date there's
2040!

PRINCIPAL
Yes. It was her 50th birthday trip.

GRAY
In 2040?

Morgan looks down and begins counting on fingers.

A photo of Marion, young, with Bill in doctor's uniform.

PHINUIT
(dreamlike, louder)
He thought it was her.

MORGAN
2040 is *fifteen* years in the
future.

GRAY
No, fifty years from now would be
2075.

A photo of Marion in old age standing with the corpse of an alien/robot. She holds a laser gun. A thought bubble says "Not bad for my 1000th Malumnant." She's still got the Redskin's hat.

PRINCIPAL
Mm, so it is. Morgan, that reminds
me, we may have to implant a chip
in you, a mathematics module--

PHINUIT
(loud)
HE THOUGHT IT WAS HER!!!

GRAY
(roaring at Phinuit)
I said shut up!

PHINUIT
What? When?

PRINCIPAL
(awestruck)
Good. God.

Computer goes black.

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)
He thought it was her! Bill! He
thought it was her! He thought he
was killing Marion! How did I miss
that?!

MORGAN
Computer died. Sir.

PRINCIPAL
Yes. It was low battery.

Principal shuts the computer gently and goes to the window,
shaking his head. Lightning strikes nine times.

MORGAN
She's alive still, the twin.

PRINCIPAL
Saline. Yes. Until midnight,
anyway. God, midnight tonight.
(choking up)
Oh, what a world...

Eight thunderclaps.

MORGAN
But we can save her, sir. This must
be what the virus is for, what it's
asking you. Asking us--Phinuit, Mr.
Choate, us too--now that we know.
(MORE)

MORGAN (CONT'D)

And you could meet Marion, maybe
she'd--

PRINCIPAL

No! No. Morgan, god damn it, how
many times must I tell you? We need
you in the workshop! And I have
rosters, grades... You don't
understand the virus like I do. You
haven't lived with it. It's random.
It's not "for" anything.

MORGAN

You're afraid.

Another thunderclap.

GRAY

I can't go either.
(all look over)
Sorry. I have my own things I like
to do. Wander, gather material.

PHINUIT

(ironically)
Yes, wool!

Gray walks to the door.

GRAY

(unconcealed resentment)
Amazing, Phinuit, that even though
you never met her...you really are
your mother's son.

Phinuit is hurt, touched, confused, all at once.

PRINCIPAL

Please, Mr. Choate, before you go--

GRAY

Right, the reprimands! Happily.
Phinuit! No more of these infernal
prooves, you hear me?!

PHINUIT

But Father--

GRAY

No! I am your lawman and you will
obey me. Or whatever worst
consequence you can imagine *will* be
real, oh-ho, I can promise you
that.

PHINUIT
 (bitterly)
 Fine.

GRAY
 (softer)
 And I'll see about finding a
 vagabond-master for you.

Gray departs. Principal shakes his head.

PRINCIPAL
 What a world. A high-society man
 like that--more dollars than sense.

Phinuit leans wearily against the wall.

PHINUIT
 I'm weary like crazy.

PRINCIPAL
 I, too, tire. So many visitors, so
 little time for me and my music. I
 think dinner then bed for me.

MORGAN
 What? What is happening? An
 innocent woman is going to die
 tonight, and we *all* know. We have
 to try and save her! Phinuit, help,
please...

Phinuit avoids Morgan's eyes.

PRINCIPAL
 Morgan. Not everything is for
 acting upon. It's not ...
 (he gestures around)
 ... all stage. It's a terrible
 thing. Of course it is. One of
 dozens that will happen between now
 and the twelfth strike. But notice
 how far out we'll be by then.

Phinuit nods, half-listening. Principal pats Morgan on the
 shoulder. Morgan recoils.

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)
 If we had an ear open to ordinary
 human life, it would be like
 hearing the grass grow and the
 rabbit's heartbeat. The *Rush*.
 (MORE)

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)

We would die in it, Morgan, in the
 roar that lives on the other side
 of silence. So yes, poor Saline.
 But the truth is Marion needs this.
 The best you can do is ask
 yourselves: what do *I* need? I'll
 go. What I need now is a good meal
 and some rest. Corbie!

Principal throws his apple core toward the trash can. He puts
 his coat on. Morgan stares daggers.

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)

Would you boys care to accompany me
 to the door of the refectory?

The boys don't stir. Principal goes to the door.

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)

No? It's so humid you might be able
 to smell the food...?

No response.

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)

(awkwardly)

All right, well. I'll leave you two
 to it. Good night.

Principal departs. A long moment of silence. Quiet thunder.
 Phinuit walks over to the desk, treats himself to a cigarette
 and offers one to Morgan, who declines. Phinuit leaves the
 loose cigarette on the desk and pockets the case.

MORGAN

That woman will die. Because of us.
 Why don't you care?

PHINUIT

She'll die, Morgan. But not because
 of us. We're ... not causes.

MORGAN

Why, then? What kills her?

Phinuit takes a long drag, shrugging.

PHINUIT

She'll die, Morgan, by the same
 eternal necessity by which the
 nature of a triangle determines its
 angles to sum to a straight line.

MORGAN

(spits at Phinuit's feet)
Sums, how can you think of sums!
You're scared. Just like your
coward father. I see right through
you, Phin. You can't think forward
from fear. It's like the car--

Morgan picks up his car drawing from the desk.

MORGAN (CONT'D)

How is it, Phinuit, that I can be
so scared by this car I've
imagined?

PHINUIT

Maybe it's real.
(musing to self)
A car with no windows or doors.

Lightning strikes outside.

MORGAN

No way in or out.

Morgan collects himself. He checks the clock. 8:30.

MORGAN (CONT'D)

Let's go, now. The guards are at
dinner.

PHINUIT

Which means the cooks are on guard.
Impossible.

MORGAN

I'm going. Please come. I'll need
your brain.

PHINUIT

You're sentimental. Principal's
right. This doesn't concern us.

MORGAN

Yes it does! Listen. If we decide
not to try, it means we are living
in a world where people don't get
saved. Which means we wouldn't--
won't be saved.

Phinuit considers, knitting his brow. Suddenly--a heavy
rapping on the door! The boys look at each other. Lightning.
They creep over to the corner and turn off the lights.

Another knock. They press against the wall behind the door.

The knob rattles.

FROM BEHIND THE DOOR

Push, push!

With a pair of thunderclaps, the door opens and Gray comes crashing through. He falls over a chair and onto the ground. He's dirty and soaked with rain. He cowers from Principal who storms in after him in a bib. In one fist he clutches a few PAGES OF POETRY and a STEAK KNIFE, in the other two SPOONS.

PRINCIPAL

(furious)

Dog! Scoundrel!

(calm glance around)

Ah. They must have stepped out.

(back to Gray)

Bastard, rogue! I will have you strung up!

Principal advances toward Gray, carving air with his knife. Gray blubbers. The Principal shakes the pages.

GRAY

Please, writing is all I have, all,
I, I -- but I, I won't do it again--

PRINCIPAL

There will be no *again*, Gray.
Selling poetry to minors, to
working children, you are a sick
man. You've a *screw loose*. What god
has got in you, man, you have a
madness!

Principal furiously turns to his desk, grabs the loose cigarette and a match from the match bowl, lighting the latter, then the former, and then an OIL LAMP in the same long furious motion. He adjusts the wick with a dial until the room is fair aglow with its eerie light.

GRAY

(wheedling, self-pity)

A madness, god, maybe, maybe... I
cannot help it--faith, I cannot! I
try not to write. I try to not
write. Each night I promise: no
more.

Gray notices his notebook under the desk while lying on the floor. He grabs it and struggles to his feet. Lightning.

GRAY (CONT'D)
 (demented, lyrical)
 O but when the child of morning,
 rosy-fingered dawn finds me, creeps
 in and greets me, *knocks* on my
 window with an idea! ...
 (he knocks on the window
 and laughs)
 I cannot refuse her.

PRINCIPAL
 Bohemian!

Principal knocks Gray to the ground again with a backhand blow. He then grabs Gray by the jacket and lifts him to his feet, pushing him into a chair. Gray is bleeding from the lip.

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)
 Poetry is no occupation for a man
 of your stature. Or any other.
 Women neither. You have no wife?

GRAY
 Yes sir.

PRINCIPAL
 But you have money?

GRAY
 No sir.

PRINCIPAL
 Drank it all up, I'll bet.

Principal lights the pages and cracks the window to let the smoke out. They are also in Voynichese.

GRAY
 Drank it--ha! Yes, sir! Damn *dark liquor--ink!* Oakier, more gall than the *bitt'rest* barrel spirit. Ink. Ruined twice, three times over! For years my inheritance supported me. Then I borrowed from family. I debased myself in endless English letters to endless distant relations. And I was still in the black. But endlessness dried up. And black turned red, blood *undrying--Mine*, I think, I write. Mine, that rushes to fill scratches, odyne, excruciation: type-o-negative! Ha!
 (MORE)

GRAY (CONT'D)

Yes, nurse, get it all out.
Emptied, I make my promises. I'll
be out forever. I'm at the end. But
there is no end. New days, forever,
new--

PRINCIPAL

There is an end, Gray. You have
reached it.

Principal opens the window the rest of the way, tossing the burnt papers out into the rain. He again manhandles Gray, now placing him into the open window and trying to push him out. Phinuit watches, frozen with fear. Morgan nudges him to do something. Gray struggles to hold the frame and spits blood into Principal's face. Morgan runs out -- but just then Principal slips on the puddle and Gray gets away. He pounces and grabs the oil lamp, brandishing it. Morgan dives to take cover behind the desk.

GRAY

Come any closer and I will break
it!

PRINCIPAL

(hissing)

You lunatic, we'll both die! My
computer is in here! My music!

GRAY

Your *music*. Oh, you are a terrible
hypocrite, Principal, to come after
my *poetry* when you waste your time
on "music."

PRINCIPAL

Shut up!

GRAY

You don't even release anything, do
you? I bet you've never even
finished a song!

PRINCIPAL

I'm still learning how to use
everything.

GRAY

You just like tutorials.

PRINCIPAL

Shut up! Put the lamp down, will
you? You'll kill us both.

GRAY

You're no artist. You don't know what it's all *for*. You're a vile little hobbyist. How can you lecture *me*, the last American flaneur? Ha! Ha-HA!

PRINCIPAL

Shut up! Shut up!

Gray coughs more blood into his hand. He wipes it on the other side of Morgan's car drawing, then folds and pockets it.

GRAY

I have sacrificed *everything* for my art. Even Phinuit. My son, my poor genius son. Wasting away in this sorry hole. What could be worse? Of course he causes trouble here; of course he hates me.

PRINCIPAL

He will never forgive you. He will never understand.

GRAY

Yes. I hope he never does.

(heavy sigh)

But I will find him a master, one of those number people you mentioned.

PRINCIPAL

A scavenger.

GRAY

Sure! And he'll be free of me and you and Morgan and this hole.

PRINCIPAL

I like Morgan.

GRAY

Yes, I do too.

Morgan smiles to himself in the darkness. The tension is slightly let out.

PRINCIPAL

Listen, Mr. Choate, I can help you find a scavenger.

(MORE)

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)

You don't know that world and they
won't trust you. I'm low-born; I
was an orphan myself.

Gray considers.

GRAY

You know where to find one?

PRINCIPAL

Yes. We can go now -- they're out
all night in the hospital district.

GRAY

Alright.

PRINCIPAL

One condition: once we settle this,
with Phinuit gone, promise that I
will never again find you selling
poems to my children.

GRAY

Fine.

Gray puts the lamp down and they shake hands. A nightingale
song sounds out the open window.

PRINCIPAL

Celebrate? Cigarette?

He looks around for the box. Morgan jumps out into the light
and grabs the lamp. Gray and Principal scream in surprise.

MORGAN

Take us with you!

PRINCIPAL

Morgan! Shouldn't you be at work?

GRAY

(stunned)

Phinuit! You--

MORGAN

Just take us with you!

PRINCIPAL

For godsake stop brandishing that
thing!

GRAY

Phinuit has to come. Why do you
want to go?

MORGAN

There's still time to save Marion's twin! You're going to the hospital district already, we can stop on the way. We just find the twin, move her somewhere safe, and leave.

Awkward beat.

PRINCIPAL

Morgan, we've been over this--

MORGAN

(brandishing the lamp)
I'm not asking! It's an--an imperative! You are *all* of you cowards.

PHINUIT

(clearing throat)
Technically, *cowardice*--

MORGAN

You too, Phinuit. You're not as smart as you think.

PHINUIT

(irritated)
I am *exactly* as smart as I think. Just as I think, I am smart, according.

GRAY

Careful, boys. Fighting hurts everyone.

MORGAN

We have to save her. Right, Phin?

Phinuit chews his lip. He clutches his cross.

MORGAN (CONT'D)

And I'll be back at work tomorrow morning. I'll work a double!

Phinuit strides to Morgan and puts his hand on the lamp too. He is shaking with fear.

PHINUIT

Morgan's right. We have to save her. To avoid living in a worse world. It's the only rational choice.

Principal shares a long look with Gray. Finally, Gray shrugs. Principal sighs.

PRINCIPAL

Alright. But behave. And stay
close. A city is a dangerous place.

Morgan puts the lamp down and goes to the door. Phinuit stands shaking, frozen.

GRAY

Phinuit? You ready?

Gray pats Phinuit on the forehead.

GRAY (CONT'D)

It'll be alright, Phin. Are you
scared?

PHINUIT

I don't know.

GRAY

Well. What you don't know can't
hurt you.

All exit. Water drips into the puddle on the floor.

TO BLACK
END I

TITLE CARD: II

INT. TAXI - NIGHT

Phinuit, Gray, Principal, and Morgan sit four across in the back of a taxi. The taxi sails through the city at night, over a bridge, through an industrial zone, and into a seedy district. The lightning storm has abated. Wet streets shine.

Morgan is glued to the window. Phinuit, who is still sleepy, rests his head on Gray's shoulder, tentatively at first. Once asleep he really nuzzles in. Gray seems pleased and uncomfortable all at once. He brushes some dust from Phinuit's uniform.

Principal puts headphones in and listens to a folder called "orphanage songs" in the Files section of his phone.

Suddenly Gray cranes his neck, noticing something out the window. He slaps the driver's headrest.

GRAY
(urgent)
Wait, here, here, stop the car!

EXT. CURB OUTSIDE GENTLEMEN'S LOUNGE

Gray speaks on behalf of the group to a DOORMAN under a sign that reads MG'S GM LOUNGE CONCEPT. They know each other. The others stand by the curb, trying to keep warm.

MORGAN
Why are we stopping? We only have
so much time!

PRINCIPAL
I'm sure it won't take long. Mr.
Choate says it's necessary.

MORGAN
For what?

PRINCIPAL
Some things are just necessary.

PHINUIT
(yawn)
Like sleep.

PRINCIPAL
True. And wakefulness. The one to
the other.

MORGAN
But Principal, Saline will die--

PRINCIPAL
Yes, I suppose she may. So may we
all, one day. Though, as you say,
we have so much time. That's about
all we do have.

MORGAN
We have to hurry--

PRINCIPAL
Morgan, we'll get to the hospital
on time, don't worry. But I can't
go against Mr. Choate on this. We
just made up. But you don't have a
head for *politic*. Well, it takes
all kinds, ha! And the world will
always need jewelers like you. Now
there's a profession.

(MORE)

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)

Good times or bad, we humans always
turn to *jewelers*--

Gray whistles. Principal looks up--the boys are disappearing into the lounge. Gray holds the door. Principal hustles over.

INT. GENTLEMAN'S LOUNGE

All sit at a table in the back of a smoky gentleman's lounge. Gray looks very relaxed and has just received his drink: a short bottle of beer. He plays with a deck of cards on the table.

GRAY

I don't see what's so wrong with
showing my boy and his lackey a
good time.

MORGAN

I don't see how gambling can help!

GRAY

Calm down, Morgan. There's plenty
of evening 'til midnight still.
It's natural not to understand
gambling at your age. It's sort of
a *man's* idea. Controlled exposure
to chance.

PRINCIPAL

It's a numbers game, gambling. All
math -- which never was your strong
suit, Morgan.

GRAY

(conspiratorial whisper,
tapping nose)
Strong suits, by the way -- *clubs*
and *diamonds*. And *spades*.

A waiter arrives with a tray supporting a bottle of rum, a can of coke, and a single glass of ice.

WAITER

I have a coke?

GRAY

(indicating Phinuit)
For the little fella.
(to waiter)
Thanks for your service.

Gray palms the waiter a coin while patting Phinuit on the head. The waiter hands the coke to Phinuit.

WAITER

And a glass of ice?

Principal holds up a finger and nods, taking the glass of ice. The waiter walks away, taking a hearty swallow from the bottle of rum.

PRINCIPAL

Always thought it would be nice to
be a waiter. Take orders. Serve.

Morgan stares at the clock. 10:00pm.

MORGAN

(shaking head)

One hour til midnight.

PRINCIPAL

(crunching on ice,
wistful)

No hearts. Who knew! Truth is,
coming up as low as I did -- we
never had meat, Sunday roasted
lettuce head -- there was no one to
teach me *tricks*. Which suits and
numbers are good, or "lucky,"
whatever you call it.

GRAY

You've never gambled?

Principal shakes head, blushing.

GRAY (CONT'D)

Well, that ends tonight! Oh-ho!
You've got to have fun in this
world, Principal, no matter the
cost. Let's see what they got. I
mean. I was going to gamble anyway.

He looks around for a menu. There's a QR code on a clipboard on the table. He takes out his phone. The screen shows his phone is locked from incorrect password attempts. He winces.

GRAY (CONT'D)

Loan me yours.

He scans the code with Principal's phone and starts scrolling through the gambling menu.

GRAY (CONT'D)

It all looks good. Truth is, I kind of have a problem! It's very absorbing, addictive--like all good things. It's possible I've lost more money this way than through ink purchases.

At the other end of the table, Phinuit has brightened from his coke. He offers some to Morgan, who refuses, then changes his mind and accepts. The boys take teeny sips, handing the can back and forth. It's delicious for them.

GRAY (CONT'D)

Looooook, they've got *parlays*!

He shows Principal on the phone. There's a photo. Morgan eyes the a back exit.

PHINUIT

Father, what's a parlay?

GRAY

Ah, youth! A parlay is like ... suppose I had one dollar to bet, but we only could bet on coin tosses. If I want to really stretch my dollar, I wouldn't just bet on a single toss, since the bookie, that's you,

(he indicates Principal,
who is pleased)

can't give me a good margin on a fair toss. It's one to one. There's no money there. So instead, I bet on the co-occurrence of multiple events: that three coin tosses will turn up heads, for example. This way when I go to the bookie, that's you,

(he indicates Morgan,
Principal is crestfallen)

you can give me odds like nine or eight to one. And now I have a chance of making real money.

PHINUIT

What? It's a way of making your odds worse?

GRAY

Longer, but yes. You've grasped the essence.

PRINCIPAL

Ingenious! It's a matter of leverage.

GRAY

You're a quick study, Principal.
Yes, leverage is the thing. Give me
a series of bets long enough and a
market in which ... eh. Whatever.

Gray coughs and knocks his beer onto both his and Principal's phone. Principal doesn't notice. Gray starts frantically trying to dry them under the table.

PRINCIPAL

(eyes gleaming)

Let's make. Waiter! We'd--

WAITER

(arriving, sitting down at
table)

Yes?

Morgan sighs and whispers something to Phinuit, pointing to the door. Phinuit whispers something back. Morgan nods. The adults pay no heed.

PRINCIPAL

We'd like a bet.

GRAY

Er--and some rice please.

Waiter jots notes on his hand. Morgan and Phinuit duck under the table.

WAITER

Alright. Cooked?

GRAY

No, straight.

WAITER

And the rice?

GRAY

No as well.

WAITER

Straight away. What sort of bet?

Under the table, Morgan accidentally crawls over Principal's foot with his knee. Principal makes eyes at Gray.

PRINCIPAL

A -- a parlay, please. Three heads
in a row.

Phinuit does the same to Gray by accident. Gray raises an
eyebrow at Principal and winks.

GRAY

Make it four.

As the boys finish their escape from under the table, Phinuit
spills some of his coke onto the waiter's crotch. The
waiter's eyes bulge and he crosses his legs.

WAITER

(strangely affected)

Excellent choice. How much money?

Principal looks to Gray. Under the table, Gray steps on his
own foot.

GRAY

Dealer's choice.

WAITER

(writing on hand)

Four heads in a row.

GRAY

And some rice.

WAITER

Straight away.

GRAY

Thanks for your service.

Gray palms the waiter a batting cage token. Principal looks
concerned. The waiter gets up to leave, awkwardly keeping his
crotch turned away from the table, but Principal grabs his
sleeve. He has an idea. A *good* one.

PRINCIPAL

Wait.

WAITER

...naturally.

CUT TO:

EXT. ALLEYWAY BESIDE LOUNGE - NIGHT

Phinuit and Morgan walk down the alleyway, away from the side door from which they've just escaped. Phinuit carries his can of coke. Morgan is wringing his hands. Both wear simple, sock-like shoes not designed for this environment.

PHINUIT

Try not to blame them, Morgan.
They're unprincipled. But at least
they knew the way to the hospital
district.

They come out to the curb. Wind howls through the strangely empty city. They clutch their coats about them.

INT. GENTLEMAN'S LOUNGE - CONTINUOUS

The waiter leans backwards on the table. Principal and Gray are so locked in they haven't noticed the boys' empty chairs.

PRINCIPAL

(wagging finger)

So shouldn't it be *more unlikely* to
get four heads in a row, than, say,
some other sequence, like: heads,
heads, heads, heads. Or, tails, I
mean?

WAITER

I am not allowed to say, sir.

PRINCIPAL

(to Gray)

Think about it! I mean, *four* heads
in a row? You never see that.

GRAY

Rushmore.

PRINCIPAL

If you let me finish you'll see I'm
done! All I mean is maybe we'd be
better off picking a specific
random sequence.

GRAY

No, I see what you mean. But damn
if I don't like heads tonight! What
about -- waiter, can we bet on four
heads *in any order*?

Principal smiles, crunches on his ice, nods, then furrows his brow.

WAITER
Four heads out of four?

GRAY
In any order.

WAITER
Certainly.

The waiter leaves. Gray wiggles his eyebrows at Principal, feeling the air with his fingers.

GRAY
You feel it eh? The thrall? You
know what that is? The raw stuff of
fate!
 (twisting index and middle
 finger around each other)
The twist!
 (leaning forward)
The inclination! Isn't it *terrible*?
 (looking through the brown
 glass of his beer bottle)
Boys, notice how the wise gambler
maintains *control*--

Principal's face is scrunched in displeasure and grotesquely distorted. He looks faint.

GRAY (CONT'D)
Hey, hey, you alright?

PRINCIPAL
 (tapping center of
 forehead)
Brainfreeze.

EXT. ISLAND MOUNTAINTOP - EVENING

A coin thrown into an empty glass fishbowl bounces and rattles.

EXT. GENTLEMAN'S LOUNGE - EVENING

The boys steal down the block. They hide from passersby.

What looks to be a haggard man pushes a shopping cart. Morgan elbows Phinuit. They run up.

MORGAN

Excuse me, sir. We're lost--

The figure turns around to reveal it is in fact a mother with a stroller. The boys scream and cower.

MOTHER

Sorry, I don't carry numbers--why, you're just little boys! Don't be scared now. It's bad for sexual development.

MORGAN

What?

MOTHER

I won't hurt you. I'm a family practitioner.

PHINUIT

What's that?

MOTHER

A family? Oh, you're orphanage boys, I recognize the uniform--

MORGAN

No! We have families. These are stolen.

PHINUIT

Off corpses.

MOTHER

That's terrible!

PHINUIT

They weren't using them.

MOTHER

Naked corpses! But don't your parents give you clothes?

MORGAN

Those got dirty.

PHINUIT

Digging up corpses.

MORGAN

We're lost. We need to get to the hospital district. Could you please direct us?

MOTHER

Certainly. Hospital ... hospital...
Why, I was just there! Got to bring
this baby home though. Now where --
oh, you know, it's funny? Ha, ha,
hA! The hospital is on Prince's
Island tonight for a charity gala.
Fundraising! So, Prince's Island:
if you hurry, you might catch the
last ferry. That's--

She points in one direction.

MOTHER (CONT'D)

--no, wait. Where are those docks--

She points in few more.

MOTHER (CONT'D)

Hmm. What's wrong with me? I just
came from there, too. Boy are my
arms tired. There...

(she starts pointing from
the hip)

Or maybe there. Hey, would you like
a *chaperon*? You'll need help
getting through security. I was
just gonna play a few rounds of
coins at MG's and then hit the
showers, pop this baby in bed,
probably eat dinner in front of the
fridge, see what the ants are up
to, but after that, hey, there's
evening yet--hey! That's the wrong
way!

The boys have long since run off in the first direction she
pointed.

MOTHER (CONT'D)

...maybe.

She sighs and continues down the street with the stroller,
hum-singing a single note to herself.

GRAY (O.S.)

(calling out)

Boys? Bo-boys? We're almost done!
Come back!

As she passes the lounge she stops to respond to Gray, who is
leaning out the door. She is silhouetted by the lights of a
van parked out front.

MOTHER

Excuse me, are you looking--

Gray recoils.

GRAY

I don't carry numbers!

And slams the door.

INT. GENTLEMAN'S LOUNGE

Gray returns to the table where Principal taps away on his forehead, deep in thought, distracted.

GRAY

They've disappeared! Come help me look outside. They can't be far.

PRINCIPAL

Call them?

Gray waves the idea away.

GRAY

The hospital district is close, we can wander there from here. It's not safe for them on their own.

PRINCIPAL

All of a sudden you care? What about the thrall?

GRAY

It's very important to me to keep Phinuit safe.

PRINCIPAL

(scoff)

Is that why you gave him up?

GRAY

Yes. So let's close out and go. Waiter--

PRINCIPAL

What? While we're down? Listen, I've had a ...

The waiter walks over with a bucket of rice.

WAITER

Your rice, sir?

Principal, having heard "your ice," frowns and reluctantly hands his ice cup over. Waiter takes it as he puts the rice down on the table. Gray quickly squirrels it away and buries the phones in it.

WAITER (CONT'D)
Any more bets?

GRAY
Oh, what happened with the last one?

PRINCIPAL
Lost. While you were up.

GRAY
Damn. What was it?

WAITER
Two heads.

GRAY
Again? We're *right there*, eh? Damn. Well. Two heads is better than none! Let's sit next round and...
(shaking head, standing)
No. We'll close, waiter. We need to find the boys.

PRINCIPAL
Wait, wait. I've had a ...
(he taps himself right between the eyes)
brainwave. Waiter?

Waiter sits. His pants are on backwards now.

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)
(to Gray)
Whatever we choose, there's always a chance it might not happen.

Gray nods.

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)
So why not hedge our bets? Say we bet on four heads. Then we *parlay* a bet that it *won't* go four heads! Whatever we bet, we parlay the opposite *on top*.

GRAY
Well, we...

Gray's eyes go wide.

GRAY (CONT'D)
...We'd never lose.

EXT. FAIRGROUNDS - NIGHT

Phinuit and Morgan jog out from a path into a big grassy field. Morgan looks back the way they came, exasperated.

MORGAN
No, no, this isn't the docks
either. We're loster than ever!

Phinuit calmly sips his coke.

PHINUIT
Don't worry Morgan. It's bad for
sheksel development.

MORGAN
Phinuit, focus! We need to catch
the ferry to get to Saline in time!
That virus was put there for a
reason--

PHINUIT
Fine, shh, hey, shh. Look.

Phinuit points to something at the far end of the field.
Morgan squints. Very faint organ music.

PHINUIT (CONT'D)
We can get directions. And fry
bread.

MORGAN
No. Let's be rational. We'll
retrace our steps. This is high
stakes.

Phinuit finishes his coke and throws aside into the grass.

PHINUIT
Yes, high stakes. There's no time
to go back. We need the leverage...
(grabbing Morgan's hand)
...so let's gamble.

He pulls Morgan running across the grass.

INT. GENTLEMAN'S LOUNGE

More empty cups on the table. Gray and Principal look worn down. The waiter comes over and takes a seat. They look at him. He somberly shakes his head. Principal puts his head in his hands.

PRINCIPAL

I don't get it. What the hell kinda luck is this? We can't win! We should have left when you said--

GRAY

Wait, that's it--Principal, don't you see? Waiter, draw up a new bet--

PRINCIPAL

Wait, Gray, we're already down heavy. The boys are probably at the hospital by now. We can't risk--

GRAY

Risk!? Risk!? No risk! Listen to me, man. We can "heads our bets," like you say. It's so simple. Waiter, try this: four heads, in a row, any order -- those are the first twenty-four legs. Heads. Next head: add on NOT four heads in any order, i.e., one or more tails between the legs. Then, on top of that, add a new leg: that none of the previous legs hit.

The Principal's eyes are wide. Coins spin in them.

GRAY (CONT'D)

You see it now, eh?

PRINCIPAL

Beastly.

Principal crunches down on an ice cube and shivers.

EXT. ISLAND MOUNTAINTOP - NIGHT

Another coin rattles into the glass fishbowl. The fishbowl is labelled HOSPITAL (though it looks like it was originally labelled FISH). Audible commotion--murmuring voices, the sound of surgical equipment, clinking glasses, and scuffling feet.

Someone wearing tall leather boots sits on a stool by the table with the jar. On the same table, a WICKER BASKET OF APPLES. People in a mix of hospital and black tie attire file past the table.

EXT. NEAR CIRCUS TENT

Phinuit and Morgan walk up to where the carnival barker is shyly hollering. He has a slight lisp.

BARKER
 Tickets! Entrance! Circus show,
 ladies and gentlemen.
 (to the boys)
 Good evening.

MORGAN
 We're--

PHINUIT
 We'd like admittance.

BARKER
 You're in luck! Youth's tickets are
 only a dollar per tonight.

PHINUIT
 What about new ones?

MORGAN
 We haven't got any money. Do you
 know the way to the docks?

BARKER
 No, I'm not from here. We roam. In
 this totally out of control way.
 But there's a local girl in there,
 a runaway. The *Borzoï*. She might
 know. But without a ticket...

The barker considers for a long moment. He checks his watch. He checks his phone, scrolls around on the home screen, tittering to himself. He closes it.

BARKER (CONT'D)
 You gonna say please or something?

MORGAN AND PHINUIT
 Please.

BARKER
 (jerking head)
 There's a hole in the tarpaulin--

The boys take off running, rolling and falling and running.

INT. CIRCUS HALLWAY

The boys are inside the circus. They peek around to the theater doorway, where someone is checking tickets.

They run a little down the hallway and spy a bathroom. Phinuit whispers something to Morgan and they run over, assuming positions on either side of the bathroom door.

A MAN in a LONG BLACK COAT strides toward the bathroom.

PHINUIT

Hold it!

The man looks confused.

PHINUIT (CONT'D)

Gotta check that coat, sir.

MAN

Oh, um, alright.

He takes the coat off.

MAN (CONT'D)

I'm sorry, why can't I bring my coat in there?

PHINUIT

I wish I knew.

MORGAN

We're not allowed in.

MAN

Into the bathroom?

PHINUIT

We can't go in there! We've got all these coats!

MAN

Oh. I don't see any coats...

PHINUIT

That means we're doing our job.

MORGAN

Sir?

Morgan holds out his hands for the coat and sort of pulls it away from the man.

INT. CIRCUS HALLWAY - MINUTE LATER

The boys have ducked around the corner and are rifling through the coat's pockets. Morgan pulls out a pair of scissors.

MORGAN

Scissors.

Phinuit finds a roll of clear packing tape.

PHINUIT

Tape.

He hands it to Morgan.

PHINUIT (CONT'D)

I think that goes with the scissors.

Morgan puts them together. Phinuit finds a ticket.

PHINUIT (CONT'D)

Ticket! Only one...you could go in alone, find the Borzoi, get directions?

MORGAN

We could cut it in half?

PHINUIT

There're some points in fine print.
"A) Void if halved."

MORGAN

Damn.

Morgan has just cut the ticket in half.

PHINUIT

"B) Halve if voided."

MORGAN

Is it voided?

PHINUIT

I think. Let's see.

Morgan sets about cutting some lengths of tape.

PHINUIT (CONT'D)

"C) Voided halves are not half-voided, by A and B., even if two have two halves too." Hmmm...
 "D) Whole tickets, A.K.A. halved-nots, are not a) voided, or b) half, cf.A., or c) two, if by C."
 O.K. "E) --"

MORGAN

Stop. I'm trying to focus on my hands--

Morgan's vision is clouding with swimming abacus beads, numbers and letters.

PHINUIT

Listen, it's interesting. "E) Whole halved-nots are not void by F and only F, see F, by D.

Morgan shakes his head and picks up the coat from where it was resting in some mess on the floor. He grits his teeth.

PHINUIT (CONT'D)

F) C, A, and B have not voided halves, as F avoids voiding not halves, but (N.B.) F doesn't void halved-nots, c.f. U."

MORGAN

U? That's enough!

PHINUIT

(having heard "that's an F," showing ticket)
 It's a U.

Morgan snatches the ticket away.

PHINUIT (CONT'D)

Hey! I was reading that.

MORGAN

No time. Help me with this.

INT. GAMBLING PARLOR BACK OFFICE

Gray and Principal sit on the floor in a dirty back office. They are tied back to back and gagged. The waiter, stumbling drunk, opens the door for a suited figure, MONTSAINT GANSEVOORT (32, amazing, incredible), who puts on an exotica record and circles the prisoners.

WAITER

Gentlemen, I have our proprietress
Montsaint Gansevoort for you. You
may settle up with her.

Waiter walks backwards and trips into a chair in the corner,
ripping his pants in the process. Dry rice spills out the
back.

MONTSAINT

So you've incurred terrible losses.
That breaks my heart. I genuinely
feel bad for you. If I were in your
position, looking up at me, I'd be
terrified. I'd regret everything.
And I'd be thinking: who is this
tall dark glass? Who does she
remind me of? And I'd be humming to
myself, to make you, me, think I
was a *singer*.

She sits down on the floor across from them. She plays with
the rings on her fingers.

MONTSAINT (CONT'D)

I'm an empath. Do you know what
that is? I'm effectively *psychotic*.
Everything you feel, I feel *better*.
That's how I got to feel so *good*.

Smiling, she stretches out on the ground and starts messing
with the chairs and legs of the desk, trying to lift things.

MONTSAINT (CONT'D)

I'm Dutch. Do you know what that
means? My brain is always working.
Thinking. Roiling. I'm always
looking for solutions and I *Never
Lose Things*. So when someone
overspends their welcome, in a way
it's sad. Of course it's sad. But
it's also an opportunity. A sad
opportunity. Which comes with a
cost. As shadow to light. Moth. Two
sides of the same coin. Is there
anything worse than tails?

She produces a coin and shows it to them. It seems to have
tails on both sides, but it might just be the way she's
manipulating it.

MONTSAINT (CONT'D)
 (singsong)
 Cola, Cola--
 Be careful whatcha orda!

She smiles serenely and rises to her feet.

MONTSAINT (CONT'D)
 I can *feel* your stress. Don't
 worry. We are gonna get through
 this. I *promise* I'll find you on
 the other side. Waiter!

She claps once, loud, harsh.

MONTSAINT (CONT'D)
 Take them to the lights.

INT. CIRCUS HALLWAY, THEATER ENTRANCE

Phinuit and Morgan, walking two across in the large stolen coat, so that each controls one arm, both heads come out the neck, and all four feet are visible, sidle strangely up to an aged USHER. Their middle two feet are taped together at the ankle. They have roughly trimmed the bottom half foot off the coat so it does not drag on the floor. This strip is taped into a gap cut in the back to accommodate their extra width.

USHER
 Ticket please.

They hold up a ticket taut between their two hands.

MORGAN
 Here...

PHINUIT
 ..you...

MORGAN
 ...are...

PHINUIT
 ...there.

The tape on the back of the ticket strains. The usher examines it, peering sometimes back up at them, tutting his head. The boys take a step forward. Usher stops them.

USHER
 Hoooold up.

He takes their ticket and tears it in half.

USHER (CONT'D)
You gotta tear this thing.
(sigh)
No one reads anymore.

He points through the doors into the dark theater. The boys run through.

INT. VAN

Principal and Gray ride in the back of a windowless van, tied up but no longer gagged. Waiter, asleep, rides shotgun to DRIVER, who nods and gives a cool two-finger wave to cars as they pass by.

GRAY
(shaking head sadly)
Alone, young and innocent, in the city at night. I bet they're dead already.

PRINCIPAL
I can't believe I let you take us to that place. I know better than that. I've known a long time I'm not lucky to "interfere."

MONTSAINT
(calling back)
What?

No one responds.

DRIVER
I just couldn't hear you.
(beat)
Whatever.

Silence. Driver turns up his Dark Trip Hop mix.

GRAY
It was night when I first came to the city, hidden in the back of a milk truck. I was all of five and ten. The rows of buildings and stacks of lit windows seemed teeth and ... backup teeth.

Glimpses of cold city lights flash by out the windshield. Principal looks at Gray, confused and sympathetic despite his anger.

GRAY (CONT'D)

Life in the jaw--not something a person has any intuition for. No atavistic signal ... crosses those dead channels. You have to learn it, go through your paces. You--

The music turns down sharply.

MONTSAINT

We talking?

INT. THEATER, BALCONY

Phinuit and Morgan, side by side in the coat, rush around in a dark, mostly empty balcony. There is a hoop-rolling act finishing up and they try and clap to blend in, but it's hard with two different hands.

Morgan shakes his head and lets his one arm fall exasperated to his side. Phinuit taps him and points -- a door with the sign DRESSING ROOMS. They race through.

INT. THEATER, HALLWAYS

The boys race crazily through hallways and around corners.

As they come flying around a bend, Morgan (on the right) spies carnies and stops abruptly, planting his feet and acting as a pivot -- sending Phinuit swinging straight into a shelf of cymbals to the right. Phinuit elbows Morgan in the stomach in the crash. The people look over, concerned. MAY (a young carnie with futuristic clown makeup), rushes over to help them up.

MAY

You alright mister?

Phinuit rubs his head while Morgan rubs his stomach.

MORGAN

I...

PHINUIT

...fine.

Phinuit edges away from May. He's afraid of her.

MAY

My you're wide! What are you doing back here? I'm May.

(MORE)

MAY (CONT'D)

Let me help you, however I possibly
can. Are you lost? You must be
lost.

MORGAN

(hopeful)

No...

PHINUIT

...thanks.

MAY

(crestfallen)

Oh, sorry. I guess I'm nosy. That's
why they call me the Borzoi!

MORGAN

Wait!

May draws close.

PHINUIT

...nevermind.

MORGAN

No!

PHINUIT

...thanks.

Morgan stomps on Phinuit's foot, annoyed at the sabotage.

MAY

Okay, I get it, enough.

Phinuit grunts and tries to step on Morgan's foot back, but
ends up stepping on May's. May yelps and punches Phinuit's
part of the stomach.

MAY (CONT'D)

Damn! You're clumsy for a wide boy!

For a moment both boys hands are rubbing the coat's stomach.

There is an announcement over the P.A.

P.A.

Ladies and Cetera! A secret
surprise attraction will be
starting in five minutes on the
main stage!

May starts to walk away.

MAY
That's my cue!

MORGAN
Wait, we need your help!

PHINUIT
--nevermind.

May looks unnerved.

MORGAN
The docks--

PHINUIT
--are!--

MORGAN
--where we need to get. Please.
There's no time. There is a life on
the line.

PHINUIT
(annoyed)
--line. On the Line.

May is intrigued.

MAY
A life? Docks aren't far... But you
won't make on your own with two
left feet. I can take you.

She goes to throw her coat on.

MAY (CONT'D)
But we'll have to run.

INT. VAN

The van is out of the city now, on a highway.

PRINCIPAL
You don't have my phone, do you?

GRAY
You have it.

PRINCIPAL
Oh. I was hoping ... there's one
picture of Marion. Right before she
met Bill.

Gray waits.

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)

A sunny summer day. Her sister's visiting; she must have taken the picture. Marion's on a wooden walkway over a shining marsh, choked with waterlilies...

Marion's smiling face fades in ghostly in the darkness by Principal's head.

GRAY

Miami?

PRINCIPAL

(nodding)

She was living by the Everglades. In this horrible metal shack. Some nights, I'll lie up with the virus waiting for this picture to come. I put it on my phone, too, for emergencies. But it means more when it comes random ... to me.

The van pulls over and turns off. Footsteps outside.

The back door opens. A dark field. Faint organ music.

INT. HALLWAY

May leads the boys through back hallways at the circus. She grabs a giant flashlight off a table as they pass through. They are whispering to each other as they go.

P.A.

...so prepare to welcome to the stage that very special, very surprise attraction you all know and love. You've asked for it, you've got it, and now you'll get it again...

EXT. FIELD - NIGHT

Gray and Principal are lead, bound, across a field. Organ music growing louder. Gray watches a bobbing flashlight in the distance, moving away.

EXT. FIELD - OTHER END - NIGHT

The boys jog a few paces behind May, who leads the way with a flashlight.

MORGAN

No, it's not random, it must be a message somehow to find someone to save Saline--

MAY

But how do you *know* it was this Bill guy? There's pictures?

PHINUIT

It's not interesting to explain.

The boys stub their double foot and barely avoid falling.

MORGAN

(whispered to Phinuit)
Why don't we just take the coat off?

PHINUIT

(whispered back)
It's cold. And I'm worried it would scare her.

The sound of the river not far off.

MORGAN

(nodding, impressed)
You surprised me tonight Phinuit.

Phinuit rubs Morgan's stomach.

PHINUIT

Yeah, sorry about that.

MORGAN

No. I mean--thank you for--

May whistles.

MAY

Over here!

They got way off course. May is over in the trees, the river behind her. They run to her.

INT. HALLWAY

Gray and Principal, still bound, are lead down a hallway the waiter and the driver. Sounds of applause.

EXT. ISLAND MOUNTAINTOP

A view out over a river from high up. Lights on the distant shore.

EXT. RIVER - NIGHT

The boys and May emerge to a deserted rocky riverside. There is a single eroded dock and an old rowboat. The moon hangs low over the water at some intermediate stage.

PHINUIT

*These are the docks? Isn't there a
ferry?*

MAY

Not this late.
(pointing across water)
There's Prince's Island.

A distant bell peals -- eleven.

PHINUIT

One hour.

May goes, stops, comes back, and gives them the flashlight.

MAY

Here. Godspeed, whatever you are.
Give your damsel my love!

A kiss on each of four cheeks and she's off for good.

The boys cautiously tumble into the rowboat and push off. Still two-across in the boat, they each take one oar and begin the crossing.

EXT. FIELD

May sprints insanely through the trees and into the field.

INT. HALLWAY

May sprints through the hallway and past the Usher, who is restraining an annoyed coatless Man from entering.

INT. BALCONY

May disappears through the dressing room door.

Down on the stage, Montsaint stands in the spotlight. She lifts two machetes. The drunk Waiter walks out leading two depressed captives: Principal and Gray.

TO BLACK
END II

TITLE CARD: III

EXT. OPEN WATER - NIGHT

The boys row under the night sky. Gentle buzzing, heavy breathing, lapping waves and paddling noise. Constellations. Morgan is focused. Phinuit is flagging. He glances through their shoulder.

The landmass of Prince's Island comes into view over the water. It shimmers, distorts, inverts. Phinuit pauses, watching.

PHINUIT
Fate, Morgan.

MORGAN
Pull, Phin.

The boat is turned the wrong direction. Phinuit begins lazily to row again.

PHINUIT
Sometimes, Morgan, I have this suspicion ... that all the world's a hypothetical. Just that, and no realer. Whatever awaits us in whatever future ... lies already set.

MORGAN
Harder, Phin.

EXT. ISLAND MOUNTAINTOP - NIGHT

People hold champagne flutes and chat in circles. They wear formal clothing, hospital gowns, or medical uniforms. Some wear Greek theater masks. A boisterous young patient, JAMIE, jogs over and covertly pinches the leg of OHN.

JAMIE
(announcing)
Almost 11:30! Last operation's
about to start. Any takers?

The others run to attend. Jamie and Ohn sneak off giggling.

INT. CIRCUS STAGE

Montsaint stands in the spotlight, holding up the pair of machetes. On either side of her Principal and Gray stand unbound with hung heads.

MONTSAINT
Debtors are dangerous in pairs. I
think we must reduce their number.
But how to decide which one to
survive? I propose ... A fight to
the death!

The sparse crowd hoots and hollers.

MONTSAINT (CONT'D)
Now to make this a really *capital*
punishment, we'll start with a
game. Both prisoners will choose a
number between one and ten. Whoever
chooses closer to half the *average*
of both choices...

Principal taps his forehead. Gray scratches his chin.

MONTSAINT (CONT'D)
...gets the machetes. Now--

PRINCIPAL
Zero!

MONTSAINT
Not out loud!

PRINCIPAL
Zero, zero!
(to Gray)
Do zero.

Gray looks at him suspiciously.

EXT. PRINCE'S ISLAND - NIGHT

Phinuit and Morgan move awkwardly up a rocky island path. All is shadowed, overgrown. Sea wind lifts their coat. They clutch each other for warmth. Morgan has May's flashlight.

A banner reads "Hospital Gala That Way (Attendees Only)" with a depiction of a blindfolded woman in a flowing robe pointing up the path. She wears a sash that reads *Caritas*.

MORGAN

C'mon, Phin. We must be close.
(looking up mountain)
Hold on, Saline.

Jamie and Ohn stumble suddenly out onto the path laughing, drunk, half-undressed, lipstick smeared. Their masks are on backwards. They crash into the boys.

JAMIE

Ooops, Mister. Guy. Wow. Look at you! What are *you* doing here?

MORGAN

(posturing, pointing to self)
Doctor.

PHINUIT

(presenting hand to Jamie)
...Michel.

Handshake.

JAMIE

My you're wide for a doctor.
(holding hands about a foot apart)
You make *this* look narrow!

Ohn giggles.

MORGAN

How far--

PHINUIT

--is...

MORGAN

--it to the gala?

PHINUIT

--gala?

Phinuit rubs his eyes in annoyance at Morgan.

JAMIE
(hearty laugh)
The gala?

OHN
(mischievous giggle)
You're already here!

Jamie and Ohn scamper off, holding hands, pinching each other, tripping and rolling. There are more people everywhere, suddenly visible, flitting between trees.

Phinuit pulls Morgan down behind a rock.

PHINUIT
We're too wide; it's conspicuous.
We'll never make it like this.
(annoyed)
Not least since you won't do the
talking thing anymore. Let's just
take this thing off.

Phinuit takes out the scissors and goes to work cutting the tape from their ankles.

MORGAN
(exasperated)
Fine. I don't care. But let's
hurry.

INT. CIRCUS STAGE

Montsaint has her head in her hands.

MONTSAINT
Between *one* and *ten*. Pick again.
And don't say--

PRINCIPAL
One, then. I choose one.

Principal pushes his chest out bravely. He holds out his hand to Gray. Gray nods.

GRAY
Zero.

Gray takes Principal's hand.

MONTSAINT
You can't choose zero!

GRAY

One, then.

Gray stands. Montsaint sighs. Gray squeezes Principal's hand.

MONTSAINT

Let's try a different game. Bring
out the Borzoi! Ladies and Cetera,
your strange attraction: the
Nosiest Girl in the World!

May crawls out onto stage to sparse applause. She has no
doglike features, besides a large bell on a chain 'round her
neck. Eventually she stands and bows.

Montsaint withdraws to the corner. The wait' brings her a
tray with earplugs and a roll of gauze.

MONTSAINT (CONT'D)

Rouse me when it's over.

EXT. OPERATING THEATER - NIGHT

Farther up the island, in a clearing. There is a white tent,
illuminated from inside, with a sign out front. The same
emblem of the blindfolded woman and painted text that reads:

OPERATING THEATER

TONIGHT ONLY - EXHILARATING SURGERIES LIVE!

HEART REMOVAL, BLOOD REMOVAL, LOVE TRANSPLANT!

A blood spattered SURGEON outside the tent takes a break from
digging a hole to lean on his shovel. He wears a Greek mask
and a blue medical mask over that. The bodies of unfortunate
patients half-wrapped in blue tarp lie near the hole. He
removes his mask and lights a cigarette.

Sickened-looking people file out of the tent, stuffing money
into a glass fishbowl marked *HOSPITAL* by the exit. Next to
the fishbowl is a MASKED WOMAN in leather boots who nods at
the patrons as they leave, sometimes tossing coins into the
fishbowl.

One sick observer is clearly about to throw up. She looks
around for somewhere to do it, briefly considering the
fishbowl--but the masked woman snatches it away. The sick
woman stumbles, retching, toward the surgeon and his hole.

SURGEON

No no no no no no --

She throws up in the hole. He lets out a heavy sigh.

INT. CIRCUS STAGE

May holds her bell by its chain and swings it. It chimes at regular intervals. Montsaint sits perfectly still at the edge of the ring, blindfolded and ear-plugged.

MAY

Focus, Principal, focus, Gray.

Principal and Gray face each other on either side of a line in the sand. Their eyes are glazed over.

MAY (CONT'D)

When you cross the line, you will
step into each other. You will keep
no secrets. Cross.

They step across, passing each other. The expression of each changes. They have switched.

MAY (CONT'D)

You are in a dirty bar.

The men look about. They enter the role-play with complete conviction, but don't notice each other yet. Gray spies a piano and walks to it.

He plays a phrase. Sits down. Plays it again. Looks up. Notices Gray. He whistles and waves. [When they speak, it is as each other -- in the other's voice.]

PRINCIPAL

Oh. Hello, Principal. Sounds nice.

GRAY

What're you doing here, Gray?

Gray goes on playing. Principal looks around.

PRINCIPAL

Where is this, anyway?

GRAY

Somewhere Gray Choate shouldn't be.

PRINCIPAL

(sighing, shaking head)

I'm not Gray Choate.

Gray stutters in his playing and raises an eyebrow. Even May is surprised.

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)
 (struggling but pacific)
 I don't know how to explain it.
 When I first slipped...hmm. I
 learned... everything's *uneven, but
 mixed up*... There's interchange --
 between lives, between worlds. This
 and that. *Anastomosis*.

A beat. Gray stops playing the piano.

GRAY
 What?

PRINCIPAL
 When I was fifteen, I slipped into
 this world. I was out riding,
 chasing a fox at the edge of my
 family's estate. Trying to clear my
 mind. I'd been in a fight... with
 someone I thought I understood. The
 fox was flagging, and there was a
 low branch, I didn't see it, it
 knocked me down and I fell through
 something. I fell into this world.
 "All of a sudden."

The piano resumes.

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)
 Gray Choate was a man I lived with
 for a time. My first and only ...
 mm. On this side, anyway. Because
 we looked alike, I used his name on
 my papers so we could share museum
 subscriptions.

GRAY
 What was it like?

PRINCIPAL
 Normal. They never ask to see ID.

A long pause.

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)
 At first I thought I was dreaming
 this place. After a while I thought
 I'd dreamt *that one, there, before*.
 To cover an injury. To get away
 from something. But there are
 details no mind could invent -- my
 poetry, I mean, my language.
 (MORE)

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)

I've never met anyone who knows my language! It doesn't exist! *That's* why I go on writing. It's the only thing that connects here to there.

Gray nods, staring at the keys.

GRAY

What happened to the first Gray?

PRINCIPAL

Well. He impregnated me. And then he vanished. After I explained everything. I don't know where.

(beat)

Once the child was born and given over -- to you, to your project -- I assumed Gray's place.

GRAY

So Phinuit...

EXT. HOSPITAL GALA - NIGHT

Phinuit, now back-to-back inside the coat with Morgan, each with one arm in each sleeve, shuffles through the gala.

PRINCIPAL (V.O.)

Split.

The boys grab champagne from a tray and very strangely bend their arms to take sideways drinks.

GRAY (V.O.)

Does he know?

Morgan spits the champagne out. Phinuit drinks deeply.

PRINCIPAL (V.O.)

Of course not.

They smile, nod, sometimes stop to shake hands (sometimes with two people at once, one in each direction). Tape binds their wrists and ankles together. Someone Morgan talks to points off in the distance.

GRAY (V.O.)

You think you can get back there.
That's why you gave him up.

PRINCIPAL (V.O.)

...Yes.

Morgan follows the point: the operating tent.

GRAY (V.O.)
You really think you can get back?
You want that?

The boys work toward the tent, nodding, smiling, keeping up appearances.

PRINCIPAL (V.O.)
Maybe. It's hard to tell. It's hard
to know if it's even real.

Mother, the doctor from the alleyway, stands by a big tree with another *Caritas* sign. She stares at the boys, trying to place them. They spin to look away, but one face always ends up visible. They keep this up as they edge past her.

GRAY (V.O.)
I know what you mean. This virus I
have...

The boys stop by the hole to throw up, dizzy.

INT. CIRCUS STAGE

May looks curiously at Gray.

GRAY
...this woman whose twin is going
to die...

PRINCIPAL
Marion.

May almost messes up the bell swinging in shock.

GRAY
You asked earlier if I love her.

EXT. OPERATING THEATER

The boys walk up to the theater tent.

GRAY (V.O.)
I do.

There is no one around, besides the surgeon digging a new hole a ways away. He doesn't notice the boys.

GRAY (V.O.)
I love her completely.

The fishbowl is still there, full of money. Next to it is the basket of apples. The boys stuff a few in their pockets.

GRAY (V.O.)

But I don't think she's real.

The boys slip into the tent.

INT. OPERATING THEATER

The masked woman sits on a chair beside a wheeled cot on which Marion lies unconscious. There is a Redskins hat hanging on the wall. The masked woman is fiddling with vials and tubes for the IV.

PRINCIPAL (V.O.)

Why?

The boys stand inside the entrance. A waist-high wooden barrier separates them from the operating area of the tent.

GRAY (V.O.)

Nothing you love so much is real.

The boys look to an empty cot and chair.

The masked woman looks to an empty audience area.

INT. CIRCUS STAGE

May claps. Gray and Principal blink, look around, dazed, back in themselves. May runs up to them and grabs their hands.

INT. OPERATING THEATER

The boys approach the empty cot.

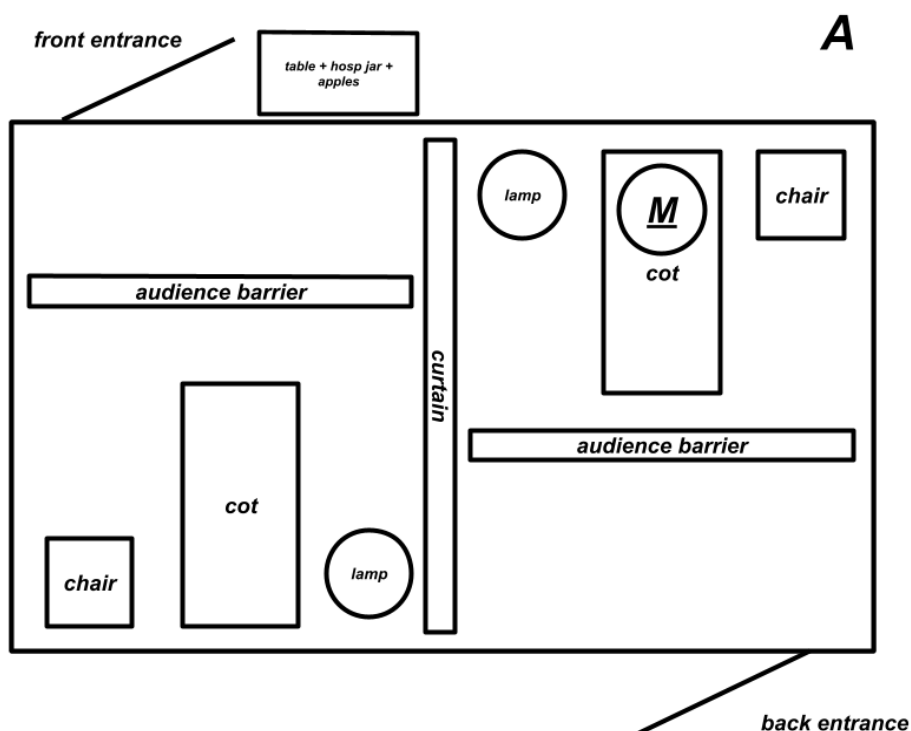
The masked woman looks around confused. She heard them.

MASKED WOMAN

Bill? Is that you? She's stable.

The boys turn toward the wall. They heard her.

In fact, there are two small operating theaters inside the tent, separated by a white curtain down the middle.



Morgan peeks around the curtain. He gasps. They enter the audience area on the right.

MASKED WOMAN (CONT'D)

Oh. You can't be in here. No more shows tonight.

PHINUIT

Who is it? Let me see.

Phinuit and Morgan turn so they both can look.

MORGAN

Ma'am, we need to remove this woman. Her life is in bad danger.

MASKED WOMAN

What? No. I mean, yes, she's not well, but if tonight's operations hold--

PHINUIT

We speak not of sickness, madam. Rather death. Forced death.

MORGAN

There's a man, Bill, he's going to
kill her--

PHINUIT

He thinks she's his own wife.
They're twins, you see.

MASKED WOMAN

What on earth gives you that idea?

PHINUIT

Necessity, madam. Engendress of all
ideas. Nothing sublunary about it.

INT. CAR

Montsaint, still blindfolded with earplugs, sits in the
passenger's seat. May grabs her hand and presses it to the
car's screen. The car starts.

CAR'S VOICE

Biodentrification successful, as
usual. Are we just out for a drive,
or was there somewhere you
pacifically wanted to go?

May's foot, with the bell fixed to it via the chain, works
the gas pedal.

MAY

Prince's Island.

CAR'S VOICE

A trip to Prince's island is a good
idea. Let's head to the ferry--

MAY

Ferry's not running.

CAR'S VOICE

Good catch, the ferry's not running
this late. If it's cool with you,
we could take the Von Narrows
bridge, since the ferry--

May turns the volume off. Principal and Gray sit in the
backseat, disoriented, but back in themselves. Principal
stares at Gray. Gray awkwardly tries to avoid eye contact.

GRAY

You don't believe me. It's okay.
I've worked pretty hard at the
language and I've long been a
capable dissembler--

PRINCIPAL

I believe you.

GRAY

Oh. So you ... feel bad for me
then?

PRINCIPAL

...Sure.

Gray seems satisfied. Principal looks out the window.

PRINCIPAL (CONT'D)

Do you think it's possible I'm the
least special person in the world?

INT. OPERATING THEATER

MASKED WOMAN

Sorry, who are you?

PHINUIT

Not interesting to explain.

MORGAN

My name is Rotten Jon Aspect.

PHINUIT

And I'm Doctor Michel. We're from
the Twins Union. Now, please, we
need to remove this patient.

Phinuit yanks on the cot but the wheels are locked. He
grunts. Every single movement is even more difficult in this
new set up.

MASKED WOMAN

Oh god, the *union*. Well, enchanted
I guess, but--no hey no!

Phinuit leans down to pull the cot harder, but this shifts
Morgan's weight onto his back and they collapse.

PHINUIT

Oooooohmph. Ugh. Ooft.

The masked woman stands over them. Phinuit's groans continue *sottovoce*.

MASKED WOMAN

You union thugs don't scare me. I
won't let you take my sister
anywhere.

She removes her mask. It's Marion! (Or is it the twin, Saline...?) Morgan gasps. Phinuit, still facing the ground, makes a curious groan. While he's down there, he unlocks the cot wheels.

MARION

Bill! Bill!

She runs through the curtain.

EXT. BRIDGE - NIGHT

An vagabond (30s) sits by the railing on the small bridge. He takes a break from cutting the number off a barcode to unpack and assemble his night-lunch: avocado toast.

INT. CAR

May's bell-foot awkwardly works the gas pedal. The car jerks.

PRINCIPAL

This virus was the one interesting
thing in my life. And I'm not even
there to see it through.

Gray lunges forward.

GRAY

(shouting)
Slow down, the bridge!

EXT. BRIDGE

Just as the vagabond prepares to bite into his toast, the screeching of tires! roaring engine! He whips around, clutching his avocado toast -- headlights!

The car rolls slowly by. May gives a little wave. The vagabond nods back, scans the license plate, and bites down on his finger.

EXT. OPERATING THEATER

The surgeon looks up from his hole. Marion runs over to Bill, accidentally stepping in the sick hole.

MARION
Bill! Bill! Help!

Bill shoulders his shovel and runs with her to the tent.

INT. OPERATING THEATER

On the right side of the divider, the boys work quickly. They move the barrier over to the curtain so that they can wheel the cot with the unconscious twin out the back entrance, detaching her IV. Before they leave, they move the chair over toward the barrier as well.

Just as the boys make it out the back, Bill and Marion barge in the left side and through the curtain, tripping over the barricade and into the chair. The shovel is scattered across the floor.

-- OUTSIDE

The boys wheel the cot with Marion around the corner of the tent.

-- INSIDE, right

Bill and Marion get up and rush to the back exit.

-- OUTSIDE

The boys continue around the left side of the tent and through the front entrance into the left side of the tent, grabbing a few more apples as they pass the basket out front.

Bill and Marion emerge from the back exit and look around.

BILL
Come back here! That's a sick
woman!

MARION
She needs that IV.

-- INSIDE

The boys leave the cot with Marion in the audience area in the left side and sneak through the curtain to the right, where they move the barrier and chair to be in front of the back entrance. Phinuit lets loose a loud whistle and they hustle back across the curtain to the left.

-- OUTSIDE

At the sound of the whistle, Bill and Marion run back to the tent and through the back entrance, immediately tripping over the barricade and into the chair as before.

-- INSIDE, left

The boys have just finished moving the left barricade and chair into position by the curtain and now quickly transfer Marion from her cot to the one here on the left side.

-- INSIDE, right

Bill and Marion are back on their feet. Bill resets the barricade by the back entrance.

BILL

Who the hell *is* this guy?

Marion shushes him.

MARION

(whisper)

Union. They think you're going to kill me or something.

EXT. ISLAND PATH

Gray is first out of the car and sprints off up the path. Principal jogs after him as May, limping with the bell, gets Montsaint out the passenger side. She discovers they're gone.

MAY

Hey wait I need help!

INT. OPERATING THEATER

-- INSIDE, left

The boys exit with the right cot, now empty, leaving Marion in the left one and letting out a sharp whistle. Again they grab apples.

-- OUTSIDE

The boys wheel the cot out of view around the corner to the left and abandon it, running around the tent to the back entrance.

-- INSIDE, left

As he charges through the curtain this time, Bill leaps, jumping the barricade but landing on the chair anyway and falling over that. Marion climbs over after.

They rush out the front entrance, not even looking toward the bed. They too grab a few apples as they pass the basket, immediately sprinting around the corner to the left.

-- INSIDE, right

The boys come flying in the back entrance and trip over the barrier reset by Bill and fall over the chair.

EXT. BIG TREE NEAR OPERATING THEATER

Gray, sprinting, comes to a sudden stop by the tree as he sees:

-- OUTSIDE, front

Bill and Marion round the corner of the tent at full speed and fall over and into the abandoned empty cot. They get up and continue around to the back entrance.

Gray runs up to the tent entrance and enters the tent on the empty left side, taking a couple apples.

-- INSIDE, left

Gray sees the unconscious twin lying in her cot and immediately wheels her out, stopping for no obvious reason to reset the barricade and chair by the curtain.

-- INSIDE, right

The boys carry the chair to the curtain and use it to get over the barricade. They then pull it over the barricade after them. Phinuit is whispering a plan to Morgan all the while.

-- OUTSIDE, side

Gray transfers the unconscious twin from one cot to the other for no obvious reason.

-- OUTSIDE, back

Bill and Marion are around the back of the tent, squinting into the darkness.

MARION

(whisper)

Where are you gone, sister mine?

She signals for Bill to follow her as she sneaks back to the front, this time going around on the other side, missing Gray.

-- INSIDE, left

The boys set both chairs to face the curtain and move the barrier in front of them to signal a new audience area.

MORGAN

(whisper)

Like this?

Phinuit nods sagely.

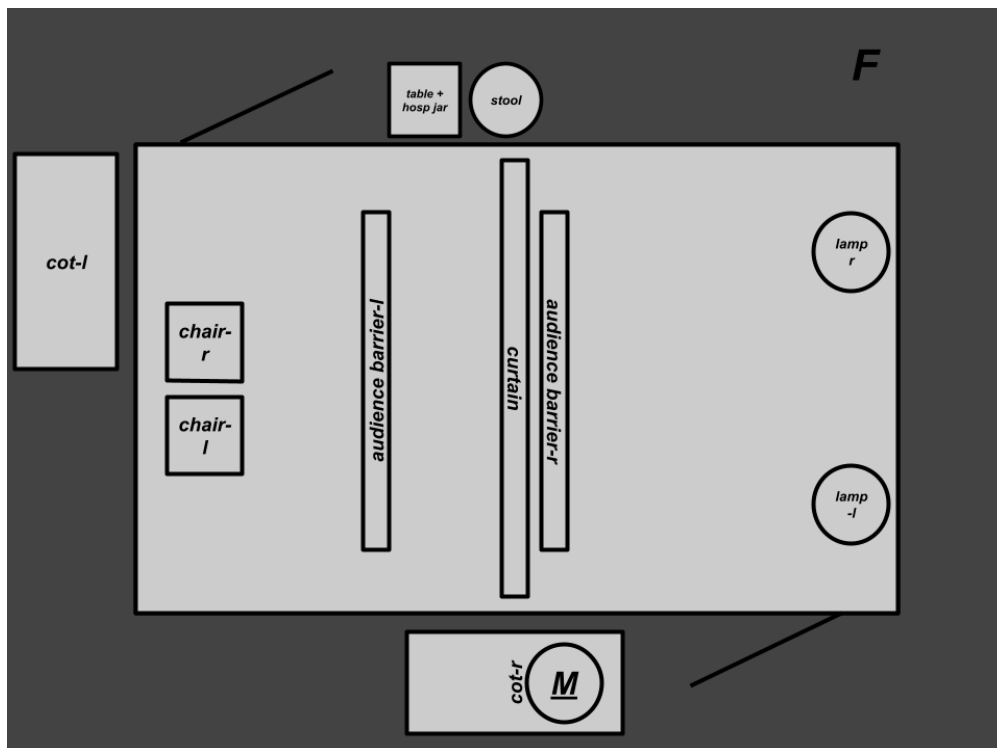
They sneak back into the right side, taking the lamp from the left side with them.

-- OUTSIDE

Gray wheels the cot with Marion on it to the back entrance.

-- INSIDE, right

The boys have pushed both lamps against the right wall and the barricade is centered up against the curtain. Now the tent as a whole looks like this:



EXT. BIG TREE NEAR OPERATING THEATER

Principal, running, stops short not far from the theater tent and takes cover. He watches as Marion -- he swoons -- and then Bill -- he makes a fist and growls -- round the corner of the tent and sneak toward the entrance.

-- INSIDE, right

Gray drags the unconscious twin's limp body through the back entrance into the right side. When he sees Phinuit, who is fiddling with the lamp placement, his eyes light up.

GRAY

Phinuit!

Phinuit shushes him but smiles. Gray abandons the twin in the middle of the floor.

PHINUIT

(whisper)

You came!

GRAY

(whisper)

Of course. C'mon, let's get out of here. Up you go.

Gray tries to scoop up Phinuit, but, not realizing the boys are tied together and weigh twice as much as he expected, he ends up throwing himself face-first into the ground.

GRAY (CONT'D)
I see. Hello Morgan.

PHINUIT
We can't go yet. Something's wrong.

MORGAN
They're both here.

GRAY
What do we do?

MORGAN
Phin had a good idea. We just finished setting.

The sound of footsteps on the other side hushes all. The boys crouch down.

--INSIDE, left

Bill and Marion enter the dark left side and wait, looking at the bright curtain as they stuff more apples into their pockets. Against the curtain, the barrier on the other side is silhouetted in double by the pair of lamps.

A shadow hand puppet appears. An eagle, soaring across the curtain surface.

PHINUIT
Caaaaw!
(affecting a voice)
Please take your seats and off your coats. The show is about to begin.

Bill and Marion sit obediently. Bill throws his scrubs over the back of the chair.

EXT. ISLAND PATH

May leads Montsaint by the hand, hobbling along with the bell. They pass a *Caritas* gala sign.

INT. OPERATING THEATER, RIGHT

Morgan finishes cutting the ticket into a shape and hands it to Phinuit.

Gray lies watching Phinuit with pride.

The unconscious twin's breathing has grown more irregular.

--INSIDE, left

The eagle flies off the curtain. There is quiet for a moment.
A bell is audible in the distance, very faintly.

PHINUIT

The show begins.

A new silhouette enters. A cutout of a hand with legs.

HAND (PHINUIT)

(sullen as hell)

Life--alack! And a lover. So much
I've asked. And gotten less. Less
than either. Less than less, and
fewer.

Marion, in the audience, tilts her head, interested. A hand-rabbit appears in the scene.

RABBIT (MORGAN)

Hello, Hand.

HAND

Oh, hullo, Rabbit.

RABBIT

Can I ask you a favor?

HAND

It's a bad time, Rabbit.

RABBIT

Need a carrot.

HAND

No thanks.

RABBIT

No, me.

HAND

Oh? No. Forget that. Carrots are
small potatoes.

RABBIT

I never noticed.

HAND
 You know what matters? One thing.
 The only real thing. "Life, and a
 lover."

Marion nods, blinks. Bill is not paying much attention.

RABBIT
 One thing?

HAND
 One and the same.

RABBIT
 Two things.

HAND
 Even so.

RABBIT
 Odd. Where do carrots fit?

HAND
Carrots! Please. Simple pleasures.
 Passions. I'm talking *reason*.

RABBIT
 You're getting ahead of yourself.

HAND
 I'd *like* to be ahead of myself.

RABBIT
 You'll put the carrot before the
 horse.

HAND
 Not a bad idea. I'd get ahead of
 myself faster.

--OUTSIDE

Principal is peeking through the entryway, watching Marion,
 stuffing money from the tip jar into his inside jacket
 pocket.

RABBIT (V.O.)
 Hand, that way goes nowhere good.
 Violence. Obsession.

Principal grabs a few apples and carries the stool into the
 audience area.

--INSIDE

Principal sets the stool beside Marion. She is locked in on the show.

RABBIT
 Passion-crimes. Hoarding. Green
 color.

Gray watches Morgan approvingly and strokes his chin. He takes out his notebook and sits up a little.

RABBIT (CONT'D)
 Cowardice. Insect. Fatigue. Yellow
 color. Red.

Marion's eyes are brimming with tears. Her mouth is open. Bill is bored and on his phone. He looks up at Principal as he enters and nods without interest.

A small rectangle appears on the screen.

RECTANGLE (GRAY)
 (loud)
 Hey sorry fumigation coming
 through!

HAND
 Fumigation?

Marion blinks in confusion.

RECTANGLE
 Yeah is anyone home?

HAND
 We don't--

RABBIT
 We're not--

RECTANGLE
 Sorry, I'm Looking for a Hand here.
 Um. A Hand?

Bill chuckles and leans over to Marian.

BILL
 Uh-oh! Who's *this* guy?

Principal shushes him.

INSIDE, right--

Behind the screen, Phinuit hits Gray, who is using his notebook to play the rectangle. Morgan's drawing falls from the notebook onto the ground.

PHINUIT
 (whisper to Gray)
 You're ruining our morality play.
 (as Hand)
 So, well, you better get that--

RABBIT
 --we don't need any fumigation--

PHINUIT
 --line.

GRAY
 Uhhhhh...line?

Awkward beat.

GRAY (CONT'D)
 At least let me sing the prices--

Morgan pulls Gray's hand down.

GRAY (CONT'D)
 (shameful whisper)
 Sorry. I froze.

BILL
 Booo! Boo. Bring him back!

MARION
 Bill, quiet.

BILL
 Sorry, no. You can't just let them
 pull good characters off screen
 like that.

--INSIDE, left

MARION
 Please, Bill, I want to watch the
 rest.

RABBIT
 So, Hand, you were saying? About
 how bad murdering is?

BILL
(continuing rant)
It's just sloppy! It breaks
immersion.

PRINCIPAL
Shut up, shut up.

HAND
Actually, I think you were saying
that--

BILL
I don't mind a challenge, but there
have to be rules. There's a minimum
of mutual respect--

Gray's full silhouette appears.

GRAY
Hey, why don't you leave if you
have such a problem? My son and his
friend worked very hard on this
trap. I think they're doing a good
job.

BILL
(to Principal and Marion)
See what I mean? Totally
ungrounded. What's this guy for?
Bring back the rectangle.

Marion puts a hand on Bill's knee.

MARION
Bill, please, I need to see this.

Bill sighs and goes back on his phone. It's 11:53.

HAND
Behind all early shining--

RABBIT
SO, I wonder if anyone in the
audience wants to confess to
anything...?

The bells seem to have gotten closer. Bill is completely
tuned out. Marion struggles with herself. She wants to speak,
she seems about to--but suddenly Principal clears his throat
and stands.

PRINCIPAL

Alright. I ... I took the money
from outside. That's my bad.

Bill jumps to his feet.

BILL

That's money for the hospital!

PRINCIPAL

Yes it ... said on the jar. That's
actually *why* it was my bad.

BILL

Give it me.

PRINCIPAL

Not giving it.

BILL

Then I take.

Bill runs at Principal, steps on his own shovel and gets hit
in the face by the handle. His nose bleeds, he falls across
Marion's lap. Marion screams. Principal smiles.

MARION

Bill!

BILL

Insanely annoying.

Gray throws the curtain open to see what's going on. He is
hit in the face with an apple thrown by Bill.

BILL (CONT'D)

No, no! What the hell are you
doing!

GRAY

You're difficult, Bill.

BILL

That's what makes me compelling.
(apple)
Like rectangle!

Gray throws an apple back. The boys immediately begin re-
organizing the furniture like stagehands.

MORGAN

Change to apple fight.

PHINUIT
Change to apple fight.

They create opposing barricades. Gray gets Morgan's drawing stuck to his shoe in the rush.

Bill throws a stool. It shatters over the unconscious twin on the floor. She stirs. Her hand opens and closes.

EXT. BIG TREE NEAR OPERATING THEATER

May is laboring hard, still pulling Montsaint. She rests against the big tree with a sign featuring the blindfolded personification of *Caritas*. Montsaint sniffs the air and grips her hand hard. She sees the tent and starts again. Her face is wracked with pain. The chains and metal from the bell dig into her foot.

INT. OPERATING THEATER

The bells are audible inside the tent. Bill counts them under his breath.

Principal is fighting from behind the left barricade with Bill and Marion since he started on that side. He throws apple after apple.

PRINCIPAL
Corbie! Corbie!

GRAY
Principal! Come over *here*!

PRINCIPAL
Oh yeah. Need anything?

Principal throws another apple at Morgan without thinking.

PHINUIT
Please more apples!

PRINCIPAL
Alright.
(to Bill)
Cover me.

Bill throws an apple point blank range into Principal's head as he leaves the barricade. Principal runs outside to get more apples.

BILL
(counting)
thirty, thirty-one.

The bell stops. Bill pulls Marion down behind the barricade.

BILL (CONT'D)
(to Marion)
Baby, we have to get out of here.
It's extremely late.

EXT. OPERATING THEATER

Maybe twenty feet from the tent, May has fallen her knees.

MAY
I can't. I can't.

Montsaint, still blindfolded and ear-plugged, does not react.
She simply smells the air, holding May's in both of hers.

MONTSAINT
Nighttime. Wet leaves. Where have
you brought me, hand?

May hears a violent scream from the war underway inside the
tent. She starts crawling.

INT. OPERATING THEATER

Principal, wearing the tip fishbowl as a helmet, has joined
them beside the right barricade. Morgans hears the bell.

MORGAN
Did anyone hear ... was someone
playing a triangle?

GRAY
I was. Until Phinuit stopped me.
And that was a rectangle, Morgan.

PRINCIPAL
Mm. I'll order that chip tomorrow,
once I get a little battery back
into my computer. Pop up, cowards!

Behind the left barricade, ducked down:

BILL
We're outnumbered.

MARION

We can't leave without Saline. She needs her IV.

BILL

Let's reason with them.

Bill and Marion stand. Bill waves his arms.

BILL (CONT'D)

Hey, hey, Ar--
(he dodges an apple)
--mistice.

MORGAN

(rearing back to throw)
Maybe so, but how d'you like *this*--

BILL

Armistice, armistice! Can we talk?
It's very late, we need to get home. We all just want everyone to live. I'm ... sorry for critiquing your bad play.

Gray and the boys pause. They duck down into conference.

MORGAN

(whisper to Gray and Principal)
We're outnumbered. I say let's accept.
(popping up, announcing)
Let's accept.

Detente. Principal tries to bite into the apple he's holding but hits glass. On the floor, the half-conscious twin's hand opens and closes.

PHINUIT

But we can't let you near Saline, Bill. You're going to kill her. I figured it out almost instantly. We came here to stop you.

BILL

What? Marion and I are the ones who've been taking care of Saline since she got sick. Why would I kill her?

PHINUIT

It's simple, Bill. You thought it was her.

BILL
How would I think that?

MARION
I'm Marion.

BILL
(points)
And that's Saline. I know the
difference. And I'm not going to
kill either of them.

Awkward beat. They're all ashamed.

BILL (CONT'D)
Happy? How'd you even get this idea
in your head? How'd you even know
we'd *be* here?

MORGAN
Principal stole a computer virus.

PRINCIPAL
Yeah but the boys were the ones--

PHINUIT
Morgan made me.

MORGAN
Well it was *your* proof that started
--

GRAY
It's mostly Morgan's fault, but
it's Phinuit's fault too. I don't
think anyone can blame me though?

Silence.

BILL
Fine. Can we go?

MORGAN
...No. Sorry. I still have a bad
feeling about you.

The others nod.

BILL
Fine! You all can come with me
then. Marion, can you take care of
getting Saline home?

MARION

Sure.

BILL

Okay, guys, get your stuff. It's a little walk to my car.

Phinuit, Gray, and Morgan all start getting ready to go, a little confused. Marion comes to sit by the twin on the ground and begins messing with the IV again, getting ready to plug it back in.

The boys join Bill by the exit.

MARION

Hey, Jon, Michel...

The boys turn.

MARION (CONT'D)

... I just want to say -- I know it's confusing. When I was a child, I thought as a child. I understood as a child. You imagine something and it's real to you. A chocolate table. Chocolate math class. Chocolate--heh. Chocolate *teacher*. But that's not...

(wistful sigh)

The world just doesn't work that way. It has its own operation in which we can't intervene. You'll understand when you die.

She strokes her unconscious sister's hair. Gray removes the paper stuck to his shoe and unfolds it.

MARION (CONT'D)

We only ever really touch our selves. We're each of us like ... like *windowless vehicles* ...

Morgan's eyes bulge. He plants his feet. Gray gives the drawing to Phinuit, who nods.

MARION (CONT'D)

...closed to the outside, operating on our own internal principle.

Principal's eyes bulge.

MORGAN

Marion. Can I ask you a question?

MARION
Anything, Jon.

MORGAN
Where did you shoot your first
gator?

Marion purses her lips and remains quiet.

MORGAN (CONT'D)
Answer it, and we'll go.

BILL
Baby, just answer. That one's easy.

Silence.

PHINUIT
It's not her.

PRINCIPAL
My god.

BILL
C'mon just *answer* it baby...

"MARION"--IN FACT **SALINE!**
I don't want to. I got tired,
that's all. I'll see you later,
Bill, you guys go. I'll take care
of Saline.

She dons the Redskins hat that was hanging on the wall. It's
now clear that the real Marion is the unconscious twin and
that Saline has been posing as Marion.

GRAY
How did you do it?

MORGAN
How could you do it?

PHINUIT
And why?

BILL
What are they talking about,
Marion? What did you do?

Saline works harder trying to hook the IV back into
unconscious Marion's arm. The boys run to stop her but trip
over May as she comes crawling through the entrance, leading
Montsaint.

May releases Montsaint. She fights with the bell on her foot.
The boys help her with it.

MAY
(whisper to Phinuit and
Morgan)
Hey.

PHINUIT AND MORGAN
(whisper back)
Hey.

MAY
I brought your guys. Fill me in?
Did you save her yet?

Phinuit and Morgan whisper to May, one in each ear, while
they unwind the bell-chain from her foot. She helps them cut
their ankles and wrists apart.

Montsaint takes a blind step towards Saline. The color goes
out of Saline's face.

BILL
It's the woman from all the gala
signs. She's alive!?

SALINE
Caritas. The greatest of the
virtues. There must have been a
statue--and then the lightning--
god! No! She's here for me!

Montsaint grasps at the air wildly.

MONTSAINT
Help! I've gone across. Hand, oh,
hand! Hand. Where'd we go?

BILL
(to group)
Which ... virtue is *Caritas*?

MORGAN
Charity.

PRINCIPAL
Expense.

GRAY
Affection.

PHINUIT
Lack.

Montsaint flings her arms wide, backhanding Saline.

MONTSAINT

Dearness, darling Hand! My
lifeline. Hand! Return to me now!

SALINE

Caritas, I know you've come for me.
Please, no more theater. I'm
caught. Let's be reasonable. Let's
cut a bargain.

BILL

Caught? Baby, just tell me what
happened.

Saline takes Montsaint's outstretched hand and leads it to
Marion's.

SALINE

(to Montsaint)

Take her in my stead.

Montsaint sits on the floor, stroking Marion's limp hand.

MONTSAINT

Hello, Hand. What's in a hand? A
bird, a tall man. A bush. The one
in the other, on occasion. What's a
casion? A diving-bell. Like they
used to build the shipwrecks!

Phinuit and Morgan are cut apart and work faster on freeing
the bell.

MONTSAINT (CONT'D)

Finger, finger, finger, five. The
hand says *five*. The first
uninteresting number. The first
negative in the reals.

Finally, the bell is free. May whispers something to the boys
and they begin shepherding Gray and Principal out of the
tent. As they run out the back door they trip over the cot
left there and tumble out of sight.

BILL

Marion, they're gone, you're tired,
let's get out of --

MONTSAINT

Left, right, why pick sides? Makes
wounds, picks wounds numb.

(MORE)

MONTSAINT (CONT'D)

Fingers the side of the tall man.
 Thomas Thumb crossed lifelines in a
 year of four digits. Crosst the
 Asabov Passage. Came in unnatural
 numbers. Beringians, Antedeluvians,
 left behind their shipwrecks.

May whistles sharply. Bill and Saline look up. The bell
 swings freely.

MAY

Focus, Bill, focus, Saline. You are
 in a dirty bar. Your secrets fall
 away.

--OUTSIDE

The boys carry one cot and the adults the other until they
 are twenty yards or so from the tent. They set them up next
 to each other.

Morgan and Phinuit climb into one, Gray into the other.
 Principal sits on the edge, watching the tent. The others lie
 back and look up.

PHINUIT

(pointing)
 What's that one.

GRAY

(pointing)
That one?

PHINUIT

The bright one.

GRAY

That's the Moon.

PHINUIT

Wow.

Gray pats Phinuit's hand.

PHINUIT (CONT'D)

Does anyone have it?

GRAY

Not yet!

PHINUIT

You should have it, Morgan. As a
 medallion. You were right to bring
 us here.

Morgan smiles.

--INSIDE

Bill and Saline stand at either end of the room. They're entranced. They speak as each other.

SALINE

Miami.

BILL

Oh. I could have guessed.

SALINE

The switch -- was it the night of Marion's operation? The oophorectomy?

BILL

You knew?

SALINE

No one recovers that fast. But I thought--if anyone could, it would be Marion.

Bill nods, thinks.

BILL

She was always strong. Stronger than I was. Juicier. More vital.

SALINE

Some people are skilled at living.

On the floor, Marion opens her eyes.

BILL

Yes. I think I could have been too. But I needed a reset.

-- OUTSIDE

Gray is still looking at the moon. His eyes betray deep emotion.

GRAY

When I was your age, Phin ... we used to call it the Coin Star.

Principal breaks his gaze from the tent to look at Gray.

PRINCIPAL
Gray, isn't there something you
wanted to tell Phinuit?

GRAY
Oh, yes. Well. Maybe not yet.

PRINCIPAL
(turning back to the tent)
There's not going to be a better
time.

-- INSIDE

Marion sits up slowly.

SALINE
Just a sedative?

BILL
Until tonight, yes.

Marion pulls along the IV tube, looking for the end.

SALINE
Why? You loved me?

BILL
Yes, Bill. Since the beginning.

Marion gets the needle.

SALINE
The beginning? Before Marion
even...? I don't understand. Why
didn't you--

BILL
I couldn't. I just couldn't.

A long beat.

BILL (CONT'D)
If I had...would you...?

SALINE
Probably not.

BILL
Right.

Marion crawls toward Saline, dragging the IV by the needle.

--OUTSIDE

PHINUIT

Why don't you say? It's better to say.

GRAY

Hmmm. Well. There's something you should know, Phinuit, about your family situation.

PHINUIT

(gasp)

I was adopted.

GRAY

What? Oh--yes. Sure, that's it.

Principal rolls his eyes. He is staring hard at the tent.

PHINUIT

Oh. Okay.

MORGAN

(forlorn)

Congratulations.

--INSIDE

Marion has the needle. She has crawled right up to Saline.

BILL

There *is* one thing I can do that she couldn't. I discovered.

Bill touches his stomach evocatively with his right hand. He raises the index and middle finger on his left. An infant appears in utero, as in a window, *platytera*. Marion is preparing to grab Saline's arm.

SALINE

You don't mean--

BILL

Yes.

Marion stops.

SALINE

Already?

BILL

The first night.

Marion studies Bill's expression. She looks up at Saline.

SALINE
The night of the operation.

A long pause. Marion lowers the needle.

MARION
(hoarse whisper)
Congratulations.

SALINE
That's different, then.
(a beat)
That's different.

Marion sighs.

BILL
I know it's a leap, Bill. I know
it's a rough start. But we could
make it work. If you try with me.

Saline thinks.

SALINE
I can't let you kill her, Saline.

Bill nods.

--OUTSIDE

Gray is avoiding Phinuit's eye.

PHINUIT
So...by you? Or...

GRAY
Me? Oh, well, Phinuit...I'm...I
have to go away soon, actually,
maybe *permanently*...

Phinuit hides tears. Principal shakes his head as he paces,
watching the tent.

PHINUIT
O-kay. Fine. Have a nice time.

A beat. Gray scratches his chin.

GRAY
I wonder if you would mind coming
with me?

PHINUIT
Wahoo Yahoo Yay Yippee!

Phinuit rolls off the cot and somersaults in the grass.
Morgan, gritting his teeth, rolls over onto his face.

May emerges from the tent, leading Montsaint.

PRINCIPAL

And? And? You're not gonna say?

May shrugs.

MAY

Take a look if you like.

GRAY

Is it safe?

Principal runs off. Gray resumes watching Phinuit's romp with amusement.

MAY

(to Morgan)

May I borrow the scissors?

MORGAN

Back pocket. Keep 'em.

May cuts the fabric away from Montsaint's head.

MONTSAINT

(blinking)

Oh good. It's all still here.

(looking around)

World.

(looking at hands)

Me.

(looking up at Moon)

Coin-star.

(seeing Gray and
Principal)

Debtors!

Principal takes the cash from his inside jacket pocket and hands it to Montsaint. Montsaint begins counting it out to herself. Principal walks off to the tent.

MAY

What happened to him?

MORGAN

(muffled, into bed)

It's not interesting to explain.

Phinuit takes out Principal's cigarette case from his pocket and starts looking around for a light. He smiles.

PHINUIT
Fate, Morgan.

--INSIDE

Principal enters the tent. Marion is sitting in a chair, looking towards the front entrance. She turns slowly to look at the Principal. There are tears on her cheeks.

PHINUIT (V.O.)
The evolution of my hypothetical.
Explanation itself, Morgan. Itself
itself, Morgan.
(a beat)
Morgan?

Marion turns away. Principal takes a cautious step towards her.

--OUTSIDE

Phinuit stands by the cot and touches at Morgan.

PHINUIT
You alright? Cigarette? Celebrate?

MORGAN
Don't feel like it.

PHINUIT
Cheer up, Morgan. We'll still see
each other sometimes.

GRAY
No. Where we're going, he cannot
come.

PHINUIT
We'll call.

Gray signals impossible.

PHINUIT (CONT'D)
Letters.

Gray signals impossible again.

PHINUIT (CONT'D)
Then I'll think of you, Morgan.
You'll live on in my memory.

MORGAN

What an honor! I can be one of your big thoughts. I'll be a real boy then!

Morgan turns over and glares at Phinuit.

MORGAN (CONT'D)

Do you know, Phin, your whole proof was stupid in the first place?

Phinuit is very taken aback.

PHINUIT

What--what do you mean...?

MORGAN

First off, how can you say only real things are scary? Fear is irrational. Your fears, your cowardice, certainly are. I saw that tonight.

Phinuit staggers backwards, blinking.

PHINUIT

Um...that's not my...my

GRAY

Morgan, be careful.

MORGAN

And anyway, even if it were true, it just limits the choice of scariest whatever. So that you're only choosing from real things. That's not the same as *making* my original choice real. It's a trick!

Phinuit stammers, drops to his knees. He clutches at his head.

GRAY

Stop, Morgan, you're hurting him!

MORGAN

You might as well have said: *the scariest real thing you can imagine is real*. It's a stupid trick. And I don't think you even *noticed* it.

Phinuit lets out a long whine. He flits around, spinning.

GRAY
 Oh god, it can't be ... we -- we
need to calm him down.

Phinuit collapses. Morgan get's up.

MORGAN
 ...Phin?

--INSIDE

Principal has moved closer to Marion. Her face is streaked with tears. Her voice is thin.

MARION
 I think they'll be happy. Don't you
 ... think so?

Principal takes a step closer. He takes her hand.

PRINCIPAL
 I'm sure of it.

She looks up at him. She looks through him with unfocused eyes.

MARION
 Twice as happy as I would have
 been?

Principal nods without breaking the strange eye contact.

MARION (CONT'D)
 Three times?

Principal nods again. Marion smiles, dopey.

MARION (CONT'D)
 You're sweet.

--OUTSIDE

Phinuit is twitching on the ground and moaning. He seems to -- is it the light? -- flicker...

GRAY
 No no no no no. Calm down, Phin,
 calm down.

MAY
 There's a sedative in the IV;
 that's what she was using --

MORGAN

Phin, I'm sorry, please, try to
calm down!

Gray shushes Morgan.

GRAY

Principal! Bring the IV, now!

--INSIDE

Marion's hand is very white. Principal is staring at it.

GRAY (O.S.) (CONT'D)

Principal! The IV! The IV! The IV!

Principal snaps out of it. He looks around for the IV. The
bag is completely empty -- he follows the tube -- into
Marion's arm.

GRAY (CONT'D)

Now, Principal! The IV! Now!

Marion's eyes are flat.

--OUTSIDE

Montsaint finishes counting and watches curiously as Phinuit
flickers and begins to fade.

GRAY (CONT'D)

No, wait, Phin, it's too soon, you
have to wait for me--

MORGAN

Phin! Come back!

GRAY

Principal!

Principal bursts out of the the tent, running toward them.
Phinuit continues to dissolve.

PRINCIPAL

There's--there's no IV!

MAY

No IV?

MONTSAINT

No IV?

GRAY

No IV? No, Phin!

Phinuit is ghost-faint.

Phin! MORGAN

Phin! PRINCIPAL

Phin? MONTSAINT

The blank ground.

CARD: FIN.
TO BLACK. HOLD.

Credits roll. A clumsy version of "So Long, Marianne" plays. Fade in under credits: the song is being performed by Waiter and Driver in the circus ring, while coatless Man, his hands tied together, tries to play with a hula hoop.